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EDITOR'S NOTE

A New York Times article from September 2026 calls to attention a mismatch in the present decade: “On one side, warnings of existential risk, maybe a 10 percent chance of the end of civilization. On the other, government paralysis.” The piece further elaborates that, similar to Albert Einstein’s letter to Franklin D. Roosevelt in 1939 about the potential development of powerful atomic bombs, more than 1,300 computer scientists issued a stark warning in July of 2026 about the rapid, unregulated proliferation of artificial intelligence (A.I.), urging government intervention and oversight. Technological change may well be inevitable, yet the pace of these shifts are what can be controlled. This human agency is the foundation of Volume VI, Issue I of the Prism Youth Journal of History and Social Sciences.

The contemporary A.I. dilemma is not our first encounter with rapid technological change or institutional adaptation. In light of this matter, the Prism Editorial Board compiled a selection of ten history papers focusing on the mid-to-late 20th century, written by students at Milton Academy and Shanghai High School. By examining how 20th-century societies navigated state power, civil liberties, and international diplomacy, this issue provides critical context for the structural challenges of the 21st century.

Research about MK Ultra and McCarthyism by authors Emmett Burghardt (Milton Academy ’27) and Lyra Dvorin (Milton Academy ’28), respectively, demonstrate how Cold War anxieties led government entities to compromise civil liberties through espionage or ideological suppression. This focus on power and public welfare extends into domestic policy debates. William Lara McCannon’s (Milton Academy ’28) paper on National Healthcare analyzes the reasons and effects of President Harry S. Truman’s failed national healthcare plan, during a time rampant with fear of communism and shift in racial constructs. Indeed, Chingmou Zhou’s (Shanghai High School International Division) piece on the Voting Rights Act examines its effectiveness on ensuring electoral representation and long-term civil rights. Media and culture also played a pivotal role in shaping public perception during these volatile decades, and Niamh O’Donoghue’s (Milton Academy ’28) paper on Norman Rockwell demonstrates how popular art captured political beliefs and social change.

On the global stage, much of the mid-1900s centered on ideological confrontation and interventionism. An analysis by Rhys Adams (Milton Academy ’26) covering the

USSR, China, and Cuba explores how tripolar communist dynamics reshaped global alliances. The real-world consequences of the influence of these global superpowers, including the United States, is illustrated in Amy Khaing's (Milton Academy '27) essay on the U.S. Interventions in Chile. Lucas Xia's (Milton Academy '28) paper about the Truman Recognition of Israel traces the origins of enduring diplomatic frameworks. Molly O'Brien's (Milton Academy '26) paper on the roots of the Israel-Palestine Conflict dives into the intricacies of foreign policy and human conflict. Documenting these conflicts from the front lines were journalists, as highlighted in Riley Qiu's (Milton Academy '28) paper on Female War Correspondents during World War II—women who broke gender barriers and redefined human-centered journalism.

The structural patterns that define history always endure to the present day. Whether evaluating the Cold War intelligence operations of the mid-20th century or the artificial intelligence boom of the 21st century, the underlying question remains unchanged: how do societies construct resilient, ethical governance in the face of volatility or destabilizing change? Our collection of papers does not offer a clear solution, but it provides essential insights to navigate the modern age. On behalf of the entire Prism Editorial Board, we invite you to engage with these works not solely as records of the past, but as vital lenses to shape our collective future.

Yours Sincerely,

The Editors-in-Chief

Emlyn Joseph, Ezra Chen, and Vivienne Mockenhaupt

ISRAEL-PALESTINE CONFLICT: EFFECT ON THE MIDDLE EAST

MOLLY O'BRIEN

Milton Academy '26

In 1917, the Balfour Declaration marked a turning point in Middle Eastern history as the United Kingdom endorsed the establishment of a Jewish homeland in Palestine. While intended as a diplomatic solution, the declaration instead intensified tensions between Jewish and Arab communities, as Palestinian Arabs increasingly resisted what they perceived as foreign intervention and dispossession. These tensions escalated into open conflict during the 1948 Arab-Israeli War, which led to the establishment of Israel and the mass displacement of Palestinians. This displacement, often referred to as the Nakba, permanently altered the region's demographics and created a large refugee population whose status remains unresolved. The conflict deepened further after the Six-Day War of 1967, when Israel captured and occupied the West Bank and Gaza Strip. The occupation of these territories introduced a complex system of military administration and settlement expansion that fundamentally reshaped the physical and political landscape. For Palestinians, this era intensified the struggle for self-determination and contributed to the rise of organized resistance movements and the subsequent Intifadas, which brought the realities of the conflict to the global stage. Peace efforts, most notably the Oslo Accords of the 1990s, briefly offered a glimmer of hope for a two-state solution; however, internal political divisions and recurring cycles of violence ultimately undermined the momentum. The enduring impasse has produced a humanitarian crisis that persists into the twenty-first century, leaving both populations caught in a cycle of trauma and a search for security. Historical evidence suggests that the Israel-Palestine conflict is central to the Middle East and North Africa because it provides unifying grievances for extremist movements and creates a structural environment of political and economic instability that hinders development across the Middle East. Jordan's role as a buffer state between Israel and other conflict-prone areas of the region places Jordan's national identity under significant strain. Its population, largely composed of Palestinian refugees, shapes the way Jordan views the Israel-Palestine issue, especially in relation to US support, as external decisions directly

affect its internal unity and future.

Extremist mobilization in the Middle East has been deeply shaped by the Israel-Palestine conflict, which is repeatedly framed as a central symbol of Western-backed oppression and Muslim grievances. Former Al-Qaeda leader Osama bin Laden reflects this narrative in his 2002 Letter to the American People, where he wrote that Western policy “slipped out of your grasp the day you made the Jews victorious in occupying our land and killing our brothers in Palestine,” positioning the conflict as a catalyst for broader resistance against perceived foreign domination. By linking the establishment of Israel to the loss of Palestinian control, bin Laden transforms a territorial dispute into a struggle where the Palestinian cause serves as a moral litmus test across the Muslim world. This framing turns the conflict into a symbol of Western interference, allowing extremist groups to justify violence as a form of resistance tied directly to Palestinian suffering. Similarly, Al-Qaeda’s former second in command, Ayman al-Zawahiri, rejected political compromise in a 2006 speech, urging “Muslims to reject any referendum on Palestine because Palestine is part of the Islamic world and not subject to any compromise.” He further encourages Muslims to support “their brothers in Palestine...so that jihad continues. [Palestine’s] liberation is the duty of every Muslim,” transforming the issue into a continuous ideological rallying point. This rhetoric removes the conflict from the realm of traditional diplomacy and reframes it as a religious obligation that supersedes national borders. By characterizing the land as an inseparable part of the Islamic world, al-Zawahiri delegitimizes secular political solutions and positions perpetual militancy as the only religiously sanctioned path. Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, former Supreme Leader of Iran, reinforces this perception by arguing that “Israel is not a country, rather it is a terrorist camp against the Palestinian nation and other Muslim nations.” By portraying the state as a terrorist entity, Khamenei strips Israel of its sovereign legitimacy and reclassifies it as a purely military target. This language broadens the scope of the conflict, suggesting that the threat is not localized to Gaza or the West Bank but is an existential threat to the entire Islamic world.

The Israel-Palestine conflict also produces structural instability across the Middle East by embedding unresolved political tensions into regional systems of security, governance, and development. This instability is reflected in Saleh Omar’s *Arab Nationalism: A Retrospective Evaluation*, where he claims that “every Arab state became fair game for Israeli and Western intervention,” highlighting how the conflict extends beyond Palestine itself and contributes to a wider environment of regional insecurity and external involvement. This dynamic has been particularly evident in states such as Syria, where ongoing

conflict and regional rivalries have been intensified by broader geopolitical tensions tied to the Israel-Palestine conflict, further destabilizing already fragile state structures. The scale of this instability is reinforced by the fact that Middle Eastern states collectively spend over 200 billion dollars annually on military expenditure, representing one of the highest defense burdens in the world relative to economic output. This cost illustrates how insecurity redirects resources away from development and toward sustained militarization. Countries across the region, including Syria, Iraq, and Saudi Arabia, have prioritized military capacity over economic reform and democratic institution-building, demonstrating how persistent insecurity provides a pretext for the consolidation of authoritarian power. At the same time, the persistence of displacement underscores the long-term consequences of this instability, with over 5.9 million registered Palestinian refugees under the United Nations Relief and Works Agency for Palestine Refugees in the Near East (UNRWA), making it one of the most enduring refugee crises globally. As Fouad Ajami writes in *The Arab Predicament*, this condition reflects “the incapacity of the dominant order to resolve the Palestinian question,” demonstrating how failure to reach a durable settlement creates systemic paralysis that perpetuates instability across the region. This instability is not only material but also political, as competing regional and global narratives further fragment cooperation and erode trust among states. The conflict has functioned as a powerful systemic regulator, shaping the ideological orientations of nearly every state in the region. As Fawaz Gerges writes, “this struggle, which has ebbed and flowed from 1954 till the present, has shaped the identity of the postcolonial, post-independence state and its conduct towards its citizens and the outside world,” demonstrating how the Israel-Palestine conflict has become embedded in state formation itself, influencing how regional governments govern internally and position themselves externally in response to the ongoing conflict.

The Israel-Palestine conflict extends far beyond a localized territorial dispute, operating as both an ideological driver of extremist mobilization and a structural force that entrenches instability across the Middle East. The broader impact of the conflict is particularly evident in Jordan, where its consequences are deeply internal. As a buffer state positioned between Israel, the Palestinian territories, and wider regional tensions, Jordan exists in a constant state of strategic vulnerability, forced to respond to external pressures beyond its control. This position has required the country to maintain one of the highest levels of defense spending in the world relative to its size, as fear of regional conflict, particularly with Israel, drives the prioritization of security over domestic investment and economic expansion. At the same time, this reliance on militarization limits Jordan’s ability to fully

capitalize on opportunities for growth and development, reinforcing the very instability it seeks to contain. Compounding this challenge are Jordan's demographics, as an estimated 50 to 65 percent of its population consists of people of Palestinian origin. This reality has made the formation of a singular national identity more complex, as the state must balance competing historical narratives and political loyalties within its own borders. Jordan's identity is not rooted in a unified cultural foundation but instead shaped by displacement and the ongoing consequences of the Israel-Palestine conflict. The internal fragility is further intensified by Jordan's dependence on the United States, as alignment with the U.S. support for Israel constrains its political flexibility and ties aspects of its domestic stability to decisions made beyond its borders. The Israel-Palestine conflict does not simply destabilize the region externally; it penetrates the internal structure of states themselves, shaping their identities, priorities, and futures in ways that make lasting stability and political independence increasingly difficult to achieve.

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CREATING THE CLICHÉ: HOW NORMAN ROCKWELL DEFINED AMERICA IN THE 20TH CENTURY

NIAMH O'DONOGHUE

Milton Academy '28

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Norman Rockwell was one of the key defining artists of America. His iconic style was easily identifiable by his signature, almost caricature-like subjects of boy scouts, young love, and seemingly infinite paintings of similar patriotic scenes. Rockwell was a stand-out artist in the American timeline by his ability to encapsulate such a wide variety of perspectives in his decades-long career with two different magazines. Beginning in the Great Depression and continuing long into the 1970s, Rockwell wrapped up the American Dream into neat, magazine-cover-sized packages for the average consumer with *The Saturday Evening Post*. The *Post*'s covers, while idyllic, were only representative of a fraction of the American population. This limited American Dream was confined to his work with *The Saturday Evening Post*; during his time with *Look* magazine, his paintings became increasingly realistic, aligning with the change in discussions that were occurring along the political landscape. Credentialed by two magazines on opposite sides of the spectrum, Rockwell's traditional, accessible style allowed him to reflect on both the national reaction toward the civil rights movement and the nostalgic feel of memories experienced by many citizens. As his style evolved from nostalgic fantasy, he turned an increasingly photojournalistic eye towards events in the South. Through depicting the humanity of his subjects, he invited the viewer to assess treatment of their fellow people on their own terms.

Continuously critiqued throughout his career as a clichéd, common artist, Rockwell did not need to be validated by the modernistic, expressionist style of his era because, in mirroring the childhood memories of America, his work grew to be loved by millions. In a tumultuous world during and after World War II, the artistic community within America rejected traditional, realistic art such as Rockwell's. As artists and their critics wanted a "new art of meaning and substance," abstract expressionism took hold as the new popular style amongst fine artists. Often characterized by a cacophony of colors and textures, abstract expressionism helped artists communicate feelings and doubts in a way that felt

aligned with just how chaotic the world had become. Thus, Rockwell's steadfastness in his iconic style was dismissed by artists as being lowbrow due to its apparent lack of nuance in a rapidly changing landscape.

However, Rockwell's mainstream audience through *The Saturday Evening Post* stood unwavering against the torrent of criticism from fine artists. As he stated in an interview, "I love to tell stories in pictures... that isn't what fine art man goes for." Rockwell's art hinged on ideas that were inherently "antithetical" to abstract expressionism, based on an easily accessible story instead of a mix of patterns and colors that were often unintelligible to the untrained eye. Unlike artists, the vast majority of Americans—particularly those in the South—clung to the patriotic and pre-war memories associated with Rockwell. They had no need for the affirmations of stuffy critics so long as they felt comforted by Rockwell's paintings, proving "mass taste doesn't need any votes. It has already won the race." Clichéd as it may have been, Rockwell's ability to make his audience feel truly seen made him exceptionally popular. Rockwell built up his dependable reputation with the American public into a robust platform for the rest of his career with *The Saturday Evening Post*. By 1940, Rockwell had firmly established himself as an artist of the people, for the people. By representing "the America [he] knew and observed to others who may not have noticed," after World War II, Rockwell served as an interpreter of how Americans were perceived and how they wanted themselves to be perceived. His work, as one fan wrote, was "a part of Americana... when the world was a nice and cozy place to live in." His contract with *The Saturday Evening Post* affirmed exactly what Americans were looking for—a source of comfort during a challenging time.

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One stipulation that came with being the definition of Americana, however, was that Rockwell could depict the American Dream only for a select group of people. Due to his contract with *The Saturday Evening Post*—a conservative magazine and the distributor and sponsor of his works—Rockwell was heavily encouraged by his editors to never paint people of color and was forbidden to paint them in any roles other than that of servants. However, despite these rules, Rockwell still managed to depict people of color by "sneaking them in" against the wishes of his employers. Despite his working around the rules, only a handful out of over 300 of his covers with *The Saturday Evening Post* were people of color ever depicted.

By the 1950s, as word of the civil rights movement had made its rounds to his small New England town, Rockwell began to feel trapped by *The Post's* restrictions on his subject matter. As an artist who depicted the common ideas that were in the minds of

Americans, he could no longer ignore the changes brewing on the horizon. The “best of all possible worlds— grandfathers, puppy dogs—things like that” were “dead now, and [he thought it was] about time.” Rockwell was now grappling with a complicated world. Despite his growing resentment toward *The Saturday Evening Post*, Rockwell had still established a positive reputation, particularly with conservative white Americans in the South through his time at *The Post*. To abruptly move away from his pattern of soothing the American people would potentially be detrimental to his fan base. Despite the risk to his carefully curated reputation, he began to pull himself away from *The Post* and focus on the changing political landscape leading up to the Civil Rights Movement.

After his time at *The Post*, Rockwell moved onto *Look* magazine, a popular liberal magazine that gained particular traction for its coverage of the civil rights movement. *Look* was significantly more liberal than *The Saturday Evening Post*, citing coverage of a variety of perspectives within its issues, especially during the civil rights movement. There, Rockwell stipulated that he would have complete creative freedom over the sources and the content of his paintings, which would prove to be influential in the progression of his distinct style. In alignment with the shift from pre-war memories to current events, he began to paint powerful photojournalistic scenes. However, because the majority of his audience were white Americans, they were “caught off guard by the artist’s change in subject matter,” nonetheless a necessary realization for the coming years. His work throughout the civil rights movement proved not only to be reflective of the national shame of the backlash through his works such as “The Problem We All Live With” and “Murder in Mississippi,” but also hopeful for the future, such as in “New Kids in the Neighborhood.” During his time at *Look* magazine, his works blossomed to interact directly with the viewer. By being legitimized by both *Look* magazine and *The Saturday Evening Post*, Rockwell had established himself a robust platform on which he could truly showcase both sides of American history with “intimated authenticity.” No longer was the viewer spoon-fed a narrative; they were now urged to interpret his paintings based on where they stood on the political spectrum. Through this style, his work directly reflected the nation’s shift from clinging onto the pre-war fantasy to addressing the civil rights movement. He encouraged the viewer to grapple with moments that “evoked both the nation’s ideals and its realities.” As an artist who defined how Americans saw themselves, Rockwell reflected on America’s reaction toward the civil rights movement, a bold step in that he asked viewers to grapple with the question of how they wanted to be seen as opposed to how they were behaving in reality through Rockwell’s photojournalistic lens.

Norman Rockwell's "The Problem We All Live With" forced the viewer to grapple with the complexities of the desegregation of Alabama's schools while humanizing Bridges, further confronting the nation with their own actions through his photojournalistic style. "The Problem We All Live With" was an immense accomplishment by Rockwell from the start, spanning nearly four feet in diameter. A smaller version of the painting was published by *Look* magazine in their issue reflecting on the desegregation of Alabama's schools. Even so, when published, it reached across an entire magazine page spread, capturing its audience's attention immediately. Rockwell ensured that, regardless of how temporary or informal magazines were considered, when displayed, "The Problem We All Live With" would live up to the gravity of the event it depicted. In addition to the painting's scale, the painting's perspective challenges the viewer with the complexities involved in the scene; the viewer is watching Ruby Bridges' walk to school from within the crowd of spectators and screaming adults—but at a child's height, eye level with Bridges. Rockwell's use of perspective in this painting not only exposes the viewer to the plain facts of the event, but also preserves Bridges' humanity. Despite the thrown tomato beside her and the racist slur scrawled on the wall, her unstained white tennis shoes march on fearlessly as she clutches her notebooks. The viewer is unable to see her face beyond her side profile, not even giving the crowd a glance as she makes her way to the first day of kindergarten, undoubtedly the main character of this scene. By utilizing perspective with his realistic style, Rockwell ensured that the viewer did not see eye-to-eye with the US marshals surrounding her, nor with the white supremacists, but with Bridges herself. Rockwell confronts the viewer, and therefore America, as not a spectator of the scene, but as a participant.

In addition to protecting Bridges' dignity in "The Problem We All Live With," Rockwell's hidden details demonstrate the painting's vagueness to the viewer. Even though "The Problem We All Live With" is firmly a photojournalistic painting aimed to address the backlash toward Bridges' walk to school, not only does it confront America with their own reactions to the event, but also leaves it up to the viewer to reflect upon its titular phrase as far as they are willing to go. Bridget Cooks in "Norman Rockwell's Negro Problem" argues that "the most pressing and open-ended questions the painting prompts are: What is the problem we all live with? and Who are we?" At first glance, it is easy to write off the title as simply another one of Rockwell's strategies to aid the viewer in how to interpret the painting. However, the juxtaposition between the ambiguous title and stark imagery was a powerful contrast to Rockwell's previous works. Before his time at *Look* magazine, Rockwell mirrored America's latching onto the past as a source of comfort; by leaving the responsi-

bility of finding the true meaning behind a seemingly simple painting, Rockwell allowed Americans to reflect on their own actions. "The Problem We All Live With" also addressed the "quasi-liberalism" that Northerners had continuously been perpetuating. Coined by Dr. Martin Luther King Jr., this quasi-liberalism was a "liberalism that is so objectively analytical that it is not subjectively committed," proving detrimental to advancements toward civil rights because, while these liberal Northerners had sympathy for those in the South, in failing to address the racism in their own hometowns, they lacked the fortitude to carry out actions of change. Rockwell, in referring to the problem as a collective one by using "We All," called for unity to address such acts of violence. In alignment with the complex emotions that riddled America's pop culture and were reflected in its art, America could no longer use Rockwell as a crutch to help them process their emotions toward historical events. This painting toes the line between interpretation and fact: the blatant hatred and racism toward Bridges, questioning just who this problem is for, either just Southerners or for America as a whole.

Just as with "The Problem We All Live With," Rockwell's later works focusing on the direct violence as a result of the civil rights movement even further shifted away from his previous, obvious meanings behind his paintings. While works such as "Southern Justice" still held a glaringly obvious center event, no longer was there a direct storyline associated with the painting waiting to be uncovered; rather there was a truth waiting to be unraveled through a snapshot of current events. Rockwell's paintings of the South, previously hallmarks of the hazy, nostalgic images that millions related to, turned a corner with "Murder in Mississippi;" Rockwell demonstrated that, from a Northern perspective, along with quasi-liberalism, the rest of the nation was no longer relying on pre-war memories and was now turning their attention to the more current issues plaguing the South. One of these issues was the relationship between the North's use of Southern violence as a "deflector of national guilt" and the backlash from the Southern states. Just as with "The Problem We All Live With," Rockwell used the title to highlight not details of the painting itself, but rather the context behind it. However, though Rockwell's initial sketch for Look magazine, "Southern Justice," was a poignant example of the national shift in perception, the final, polished painting lacked the key details that were so striking. "Murder in Mississippi," while it did indeed provide necessary context to the viewer, confined the concept of violence simply to a specific state, not to the South as a whole; as a result, "all that anger that was in the sketch had gone out of it." On the other hand, using "Southern Justice" as the titular phrase effectively communicates the complete opposite. Rockwell asks the

viewer just what is considered acceptable for violent acts during the civil rights movement, especially because “the term “Southern Justice” is apt in that it connotes something quite different from the idea of ‘American Justice.’” Violence in the South at the time was often written off as simply “Southern Justice,” the excuse that racial violence was bound to occur, under the pretense that such events never happened in the North. Rockwell set aside this Northern attitude and pushed past the barriers that kept the North dismissive of violence in the South. Rockwell addressed the whole nation by referring simply to the South, emphasizing the double standards between the North and the South and bringing in themes of liberalism from “The Problem We All Live With” to consolidate the ever-strengthening divide between two different worlds.

These paintings, while they are only a few pieces in the puzzle that make up Norman Rockwell’s legacy, are simply a few examples of how his works were shaped to fit the timeline they were created in. Rockwell’s almost mirror-like capabilities in highlighting details that were overlooked and the reach of his talent across America through both his style and magazines shaped how Americans identified themselves during a turbulent time. He challenged and comforted the population through both World Wars, the civil rights movement, and everything in between. Even in the twenty-first century, his paintings are still being interpreted by a variety of different perspectives. His patriotic paintings from the beginning of his career, for example, were taken by the Department of Homeland Security without his family’s permission and used to perpetuate hateful rhetoric against immigrants; to his surviving family, this interpretation lacked the “nuanced approach” that Rockwell originally intended. The Department of Homeland Security, in using Rockwell’s paintings, used his work to their advantage, trying to revive, as his granddaughter put it, “a segregationist past.” The Department of Homeland Security’s use of Rockwell’s paintings, while a controversial one indeed, exemplified just how interpretable his works were. On the other hand, former president Barack Obama requested for “The Problem We All Live With” to be hung in the West Wing of the White House, inviting Ruby Bridges herself to view it and speak with Obama. An absence of a “nuanced approach” was inevitable with any work of visual art, and that absence truly portrays the diverse opinions America has for itself and for Rockwell. These two examples of just how differently Rockwell’s paintings are still interpreted in the modern age exemplify how applicable Rockwell’s art was to the American people. Combining countless layers of meaning behind his seemingly simple paintings and cozy style allowed decades of Americans to pick and choose how they wanted to be seen. A timeless artist, Rockwell captured a broad spectrum of political beliefs

into a single lifelong career; through his later years, by questioning his readers with the question of not only how they wanted to be depicted, but who they wanted to be, Rockwell welcomed the complexities of such an intricate political and cultural spectrum.

Appendix



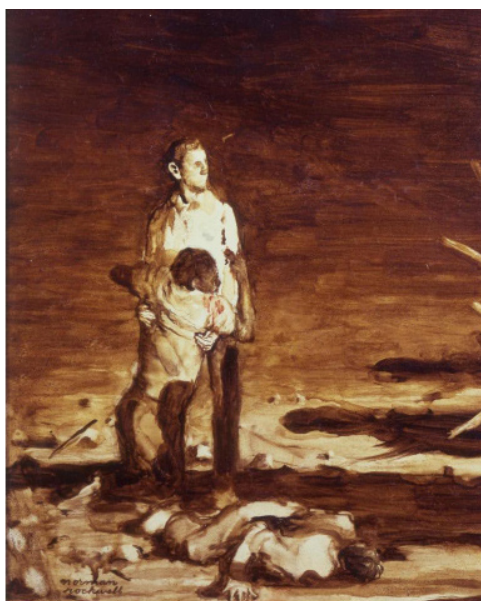
NORMAN ROCKWELL MUSEUM

Norman Rockwell, *The Problem We All Live With*, 1963, oil on canvas, 36 x 58 inches. Illustration for *LOOK*, January 14, 1964. Norman Rockwell Museum Collections.



NORMAN ROCKWELL MUSEUM

Fig. 2: Rockwell, Norman. *Murder in Mississippi*. 1965. Oil on canvas. Norman Rockwell Museum, Stockbridge, MA. Accessed April 8, 2026. <https://prints.nrm.org/detail/502591/rockwell-murder-in-mississippi-southern-justice-1965?srsltid=AfmBOopPp70cg0dWUuStpgnFOUoEk4aXm9-n29EU4tLD14OhcvTVBo>.



NORMAN ROCKWELL MUSEUM

Fig. 3: Rockwell, Norman. *Southern Justice*. 1965. Oil on canvas. Norman Rockwell Museum, Stockbridge, MA. Accessed April 8, 2026. <https://prints.nrm.org/detail/499705/rockwell-murder-in-mississippi-1965?srsltid=AfmBOor-ZlErvpJKSK3nZBqsC-S22OfKCV7szCmQSQAlE0lvVEQmYw6V3>.

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“ABJECT COWARDICE” AND PUBLIC IMAGE: DEBUNKING THE MYTH OF HARVARD UNIVERSITY’S RESISTANCE AGAINST MCCARTHYISM

LYRA DVORIN

Milton Academy ‘28

On February 9, 1950, Wisconsin Senator Joseph McCarthy delivered a speech claiming that the United States’ State Department “harbor[ed] a nest of Communists and Communist sympathizers who are helping to shape our foreign policy.” This speech acted as a catalyst for the senator’s namesake movement, McCarthyism, which spread like wildfire across the United States during the early 1950s. At this time, communism was growing in strength both in the Soviet Union, with the Cold War and the creation of the first Soviet atomic bomb, and in China, with Chinese communists winning their civil war. Spurred by this broader Second Red Scare, McCarthyism sought to root out and blacklist Communist Party members in all areas of American life. By 1956, an estimated 13.5 million Americans had undergone some form of mandatory loyalty test or investigation—as a result of McCarthyism—in order to maintain employment. In addition to enduring severe investigation, many Americans under suspicion committed suicide in order to escape McCarthyism-induced terror. Amongst the most targeted were academic institutions: as longstanding pillars of intellectual freedom, universities were, according to McCarthy, safe havens for communists and ideological dissidents. By 1952, Harvard University became a major target of the McCarthy agenda—the name Harvard was “almost synonymous with all that was evil in education,” reported *The Harvard Crimson*, the university’s student-run undergraduate newspaper. Subsequently, the university was forced to decide how to respond both internally and externally to the McCarthy agenda. Although Harvard cultivated an image of deep commitment to academic freedom in the face of McCarthyism, Harvard’s response to McCarthyist threats—through their investigation into longstanding community members and the requirements for newly appointed faculty—marked a shift away from academic freedom for the university and suppressed ideological diversity within the institution.

For decades prior to the rise of Senator Joseph McCarthy, the United States had greatly feared the influence of communism. McCarthy did not invent the concept of prosecuting communists but rather came to power at a time when the United States was particularly susceptible to his extremist views and plans. He collaborated with the already established House Un-American Activities Committee (HUAC), originally founded secretly in 1938 to investigate domestic fascist groups. The HUAC held congressional hearings for citizens suspected of communist ties. Additionally, McCarthy chaired the Committee on Government Operations' Permanent Subcommittee on Investigations. As subcommittee chair, he led investigations into perceived communist influence within the United States government, including the State Department, the U.S. Army, and the Government Printing Office. These investigations, often joint with the Federal Bureau of Investigations (FBI), consisted of research, hearings, and loyalty tests that frequently resulted in loss of employment or even jail time—often not for actual communism but for contempt of Congress, perjury, or violation of the Smith Act by refusing to cooperate with anti-communist questioning. Throughout his time in power, McCarthy targeted suspected current and former members of the Communist Party, initially only within the federal government but eventually across all forms of employment in the United States.

McCarthyism rapidly spread to the academic sector, as many Americans feared that teachers and professors would impart their ideological beliefs—in this case, communism—to their pupils. Anne Rogers Minor, a president of the Daughters of the American Revolution, stated her belief that there should be “no [educators] ... who care more for their ‘academic freedom of speech’ and opinion (so called) than for their country.” She went on to explain that, “academic freedom of speech has no place in [educational institutions], where the youth of our country are taught and their unformed minds are developed.” This sentiment was echoed across the country, leading to a crackdown on communists in education, particularly in well-known universities such as those in the Ivy League. Many professors chose to stand up against these McCarthyist efforts, but resistance—or lack thereof—ultimately became the responsibility of the universities’ administrations, who held the overarching power. In order to maintain a teaching position at many schools, each professor was, according to former Boston University professor Maurice Halperin, ...expected first to state his political beliefs and affiliations; second to state those of others with whom he has been associated; third, to expose himself to accusations against which adequate defense is possible only through normal court procedures; fourth, to refrain from invoking the Constitution of the United States to protect himself from these abuses.

Halperin's assessment demonstrated the pressures on educators in this time period: they were forced to succumb to federal influence or lose their appointments and, therefore, their livelihoods.

While many universities suffered during this era, Harvard, a recurrent defender of academic freedom, was specifically targeted by McCarthyists. This instance was not the first time that Harvard had faced off against threats to academic freedom; in the 1930s, Harvard had been labeled the "Kremlin on the Charles" for alleged radicalism—a name used to mock the university as a bastion of liberal and communist sympathizers—and had faced increasing political pressure. Despite this outside influence, during the 1930s, the institution largely chose to protect faculty freedoms and refused to fire tenured professors. Harvard chose to fight the federal government, openly inviting criticism, citing their core value of academic freedom. Subsequently, it is commonly believed that Harvard continued this pattern of defending academic freedom during the McCarthy Era.

For outsiders, Harvard attempted to construct a public image of resistance to McCarthyism, fearing criticism and loss of funding. McCarthy himself criticized Harvard President Nathan Pusey as "a man who... appears to hide a combination of bigotry and intolerance behind a cloak of phoney, hypocritical liberalism." Elaborating, the senator stated that "while he [Pusey] professes a sincere dislike for Communism, his hatred and contempt appear to be infinitely greater for those who effectively expose Communists ... He is what could be best described as a rabid... anti-Communist." These statements would appear to suggest resistance by the university and its president against McCarthy, as the senator was angered by Pusey's policies and opinions. Harvard's own paper, *The Harvard Crimson*, wrote that, "the University, acting on a long tradition of academic freedom, [has held] firm against the general craze to find subversive scapegoats and against the particular abuses of Senator McCarthy," alleging the university's defiance and separating Harvard from other, theoretically more cooperative universities. Harvard Dean for the Faculty of Arts and Sciences McGeorge Bundy explained in an April 27, 1955 letter to the Harvard Corporation—Harvard's five-person governing board—that the Corporation faced a "danger of outside criticism" if they appeared to simply dismiss suspected communists from their faculty appointments without fair investigation. Bundy's fear was echoed in many of the university's decisions regarding McCarthyism, as Harvard strove to manufacture a public image as a guardian of academic freedom. This public presentation hid much of what occurred behind the scenes. Harvard graduate Robert Bellah characterized Harvard's policy as "a discreet collaboration with McCarthyism with the primary

concern of avoiding criticism,” by generally hiding dismissals and investigations into current and former Communist Party members. Drawing attention to occasions of resistance to political pressure, university leaders went so far as to present themselves as upstanders against the McCarthy agenda. Consequently, Harvard was “widely acclaimed as a bastion of academic freedom,” recalled Harvard graduate Leon Kamin; however, according to Kamin, the insincerity of this statement made the respect “wholly undeserved.” This image of resistance was merely a facade that Harvard used to shield itself from public scrutiny.

In contrast to their public presentation of opposition to McCarthyism, Harvard conducted private investigations into longstanding community members, threatening their positions at the university and defining a turning point in the university’s policy on intellectual freedom. Bundy required all former Communist Party members, in order to be kept on, to provide the FBI with a “full and complete account of their activities in the Communist Party” and to subsequently identify all other Communist Party members known to them. This mandate demonstrated the university’s shift away from academic freedom, as professors were no longer permitted to keep information about their pasts private. Instead, they were forced either to accept dismissal from Harvard or to reveal personal—and possibly condemning—information. If a professor was found to be a current member of the Communist Party, they would be fired regardless of whether or not they had tenure. Professor Wendell Furry, a tenured Harvard physics professor, admitted under oath to being a former communist but stated that he was no longer a member of the Party. That “Wendell had tenure” was a particular point of “concern” for coworkers, explained Edward Purcell, a fellow physics professor, because tenure had formerly protected faculty members from this type of inspection. Like many targeted professors, Furry took refuge behind the Fifth Amendment—the right to refuse answering questions in order to avoid self-incrimination—by declining to answer questions from the HUAC, McCarthy, and the Harvard Corporation regarding the identities of his former comrades. The Corporation subsequently charged him with “grave misconduct” and immediately placed him on three years’ probation. The university’s failure to respect Furry’s constitutional rights demonstrated a deviation from historical university values. On December 17, 1954, Furry was federally indicted on ten counts of contempt toward Congress: “the misdemeanor of refusing to answer questions of a Senatorial committee concerning other people,” explained President Pusey. Harvard refused to come to Furry’s defense in court and instead aided the prosecution despite Furry’s longstanding commitment to the Harvard community. In a November 1953 statement about Furry, Pusey claimed that “a member of the Communist Party is not fit to be on the

faculty because he has not the necessary independence of thought and judgment.” Pusey’s blatant unwillingness to support Furry revealed Harvard’s compliance with the McCarthy agenda, undermining the myth of the university’s opposition. Though Furry was eventually acquitted in June of 1956 and managed to retain his Harvard appointment, the precedent set by the Corporation’s investigation into him demonstrated a deep shift in Harvard’s policy on academic freedom.

Furry was not the only Harvard community member who suffered from harsh investigation during the 1950s. Leon Kamin was an untenured graduate student, teaching fellow, and research assistant in social relations at Harvard. While an undergraduate, he had joined the Communist Party in 1945 but later elected to leave the party in 1950. During his pursuit of a Ph.D. at the university, Kamin, as he wrote in a letter to the *New York Review* years later, was “subpoenaed . . . and asked to “name names” of others who were involved in the Communist Party. He continued:

I declined to answer questions, citing my Fifth Amendment privilege to remain silent. I explained that my use of the Fifth Amendment stemmed from legal advice that if I answered any of the committee’s questions, I would be compelled to give the names of colleagues—who, like myself, were guilty of no crime.

His legal defense was constitutionally sound under the protections of the Fifth Amendment of the United States, and yet it led him to being charged with “misconduct” by the Harvard Corporation. Blatant disregard for this major constitutional amendment—used in many court cases across United States history—again displayed a major shift in Harvard’s policy on academic freedom. While university oversight of freedom of speech had always been in tension with the First Amendment, the Fifth Amendment was generally accepted by universities as a valid defense. One member of the Corporation alleged that, if Kamin received a degree from the university after his refusal to submit to McCarthyist questioning, “Harvard would suffer grave embarrassment.” This statement demonstrated a drastic shift in Harvard’s motivations: previously, the Corporation focused on avoiding public disapproval of the university’s compliance with the McCarthy agenda, but—by January of 1954—the Corporation feared “embarrassment” if they did not fall in line. Subsequently, Harvard refused to come to Kamin’s defense when he was indicted on six counts of contempt of Congress. Though the indictment was later dropped, Kamin related in a 2017 interview that “it left [him] unemployable in the United States.” Senator McCarthy himself—as reported by *The New York Times* in 1956—said “the contempt case against Mr. Furry, a Harvard professor was almost identical [to that of Mr. Kamin],” documenting

that the same battle was repeatedly fought against Harvard faculty with the same result: Harvard's refusal to defend community members. Through Harvard's investigation and treatment of both Furry and Kamin, the university revealed their compliance with McCarthy—a turning point in the university's relationship with academic freedom, as tenure and community standing had previously protected community members from prosecution. Harvard's policy changes during McCarthyism expanded beyond investigations into existing community members: the university also implemented harsh requirements for applicants that prevented current and former communists from gaining positions at Harvard. One such applicant, Harvard-educated sociologist Robert Bellah, had been a member of the Communist Party from 1947 through 1949, mainly as a leader of the John Reed Club—a discussion group focused on Marxism—which was officially recognized by the university. In the spring of 1955, the Department of Social Relations put Bellah up for a faculty appointment despite his history with the Communist Party. Bundy requested that Bellah undergo comprehensive mental health screening by the Harvard Health Service because, as he put it, an ex-communist must be “crazy.” This form of psychological manipulation allowed the Harvard Corporation to keep many ex-communists out of office simply on the grounds that they were not mentally stable enough to serve as faculty members. Eventually, Bellah was offered an appointment on the condition that “if, during Mr. Bellah's year of service as instructor, he should refuse to testify about any past association with communists, the Corporation would not look with favor on any proposal for his re-appointment,” as Pusey wrote in a letter to Bundy on May 16 of 1955. The Corporation's refusal to ensure Bellah's appointment unless he “named names” demonstrated the harsh employment requirements that Harvard implemented during this era. Bundy feared that if, in some way, Bellah were called as a witness and refused to cooperate, the university would be accused of “deliberately hiring” such a person. Bundy's fear emphasized the shift in Harvard's outlook on McCarthyism: the fear that the university would be seen as a rebel, contrasting previous concerns that the university would be perceived negatively for complying with McCarthy.

Harvard's obsession with public image translated directly to their handling of ex-communists. Department of Social Relations Chair Talcott Parsons wrote in a 1955 memorandum to the Harvard Corporation that “the Corporation had acted with a degree of deviousness which [was] unworthy of the Governing Board of a great university.” Parsons believed that the Corporation's actions indicated a turning point for Harvard as an institution, as it was directly opposing the morals for which it was supposed to stand. Pusey

responded to Parsons' memorandum, explaining that the Corporation "[felt] their action taken at that time [May 16, 1955] was the correct one, and, if circumstances were the same today, they would take the same attitude again." Pusey defended the Harvard Corporation's choices about Bellah's hiring and refused to further consider Parsons' concerns. By doubling down on the university's decisions, Pusey emphasized Harvard's commitment to complying with the McCarthy agenda, even if it meant turning away from the historical tendencies of the university.

In another example, Harvard's handling of Harvard graduate Sigmund Diamond's potential faculty appointment again showcased the university's support of McCarthy. After completing his doctorate at Harvard in 1953, Diamond remained on as a research fellow. Then, in 1954, Diamond was considered for appointment as Counselor for Foreign Students and Dean of Special Students. Despite having formerly been a member of the Communist Party from 1941 to 1950, Diamond believed that this aspect of his past would not prevent him from receiving a faculty position at Harvard, until he was called to Bundy's office to discuss "if there was anything about [his] history that might embarrass Harvard," as Diamond later recalled. Though this statement could theoretically refer to many different potential transgressions in Diamond's past, the assumption that this meeting purely existed as an investigation into Diamond's membership in the Communist Party is not only reasonable but probable. Diamond discovered later that each of the meetings that he subsequently had with Bundy and Pusey were taped without his permission. These tapes could then serve as leverage against Diamond throughout the investigation; this clear violation on the part of Harvard demonstrated the lengths to which the university was willing to go in order to comply with McCarthy. After Diamond refused to reveal names of members of the Communist Party to the FBI, Bundy withdrew Diamond's appointment. Diamond's history with communism eliminated his opportunity to remain at Harvard, as the requirements of his hiring involved his betraying former comrades and condemning them to relentless investigation or even jail time. Harvard's treatment of Bellah and Diamond further revealed the university's shift in rhetoric around academic freedom and McCarthyism.

During the McCarthy Era, Harvard University complied with external political pressure, investigating members of its own community and implementing new requirements for incoming faculty. These policies exemplified a shift in Harvard's relationship with academic freedom as a concept. Ultimately, Harvard's resistance against McCarthyism—something that the university is still praised for today—was merely a "myth," as Bel-

lah wrote in a letter to *The New York Review*. With Harvard's stature and renown, the university could have used their influence to opportunity to initiate a national pushback against the threat to academic freedom but instead chose to quietly comply with McCarthy, while still preserving their public image. A more complete image of Harvard in McCarthyist times paints the university not as a "bulwark" against McCarthy, as Bellah put it, but as a cowardly institution submitting to political pressure and quietly surrendering their previous loyalty to academic and intellectual freedom. This capitulation, Bellah continued, was "tempered only by a concern that the Harvard administration not do something that would rouse even more criticism than not cooperating with McCarthy would, such as firing someone with tenure." For centuries, since its founding in 1636, Harvard had featured an intellectually diverse student and teaching body, but McCarthyism saw a shift away from this diversity to a more single minded—and less politically threatening—institution. Even though McCarthyism ostensibly concluded by the end of the 1950s and the fear of communism slowly decayed, censorship and threats to academic freedom persist, even in modern times. Protecting true academic freedom is an insurmountable task, and Harvard during the McCarthy era demonstrated the ease with which a powerful institution can succumb to intense political pressure, no matter their stated moral values.

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TWISTED SPEECH AND OVERREACH: MK-ULTRA AND THE AMERICAN PUBLIC

EMMETT BURGHARDT

Milton Academy '27

On June 6, 1968, Sirhan Sirhan, a Palestinian-Jordanian man, shot and killed Senator Robert F. Kennedy outside the PIH Health Hospital in Los Angeles. Immediately after he fired his first shots, several nearby Los Angeles police officers tackled him to the ground, yet Sirhan, slight in stature at five foot five inches tall, maintained an extraordinary grip on the .22 caliber pistol, firing an additional five shots before the officers wrestled the gun from his hand. Remarkably, Sirhan remained incredibly calm in those chaotic moments; one police officer at the scene described Sirhan as having a “blank, glassed-over look on his face — like he wasn’t in complete control of his mind,” a characteristic consistent with people under hypnosis, introducing the possibility that his mind could have been conditioned through hypnosis to force him to kill Kennedy. In later testimonies, Sirhan persistently claimed that he recalled all of the events from June 6, except for the moment when he actually shot Kennedy. While in prison, several tests proved that his mind could easily be hypnotized into committing acts that he would not usually do, such as climb the bars in his cell. The combination of the tests and his impaired recollection led many to the conclusion that he had acted under hypnosis, a conclusion that his defense team chose to use in his 1969 trial. The CIA pioneered this method of hypnosis during the Cold War in several of their MK-ULTRA projects, a program designed to control the behavior of a person through controlling their mind. Even if the CIA did not pull the actual trigger and shoot RFK, the CIA could have been involved in his death through their development of mind control techniques in MK-ULTRA. Similarly connected to MK-ULTRA, Theodore Kaczynski—better known as the Unabomber—unknowingly volunteered for a MK-ULTRA experiment whilst attending Harvard University. The project, headed by psychologist Henry A. Murray, involved berating the subjects about their political beliefs for hours on end. Murray then covertly reported the data to the CIA for use in MK-ULTRA. At the time, Kaczynski had been developing his ideas and beliefs on technological society, and the over 200 hours he spent in the program likely exacerbated some of his beliefs around technological society, leading to his bombing campaign involving the deaths of three Americans,

the injury of twenty-three more, and the bombing of a passenger airliner. In both cases of the Unabomber and Sirhan Sirhan, the CIA may not have actually forced them to commit the atrocities, yet the Agency's involvement through MK-ULTRA could not have helped the situation. Both of these high-profile cases took place during the Cold War, the peak of the CIA's power and influence in America, the height of major political scandals in the twentieth century, and the apex of the ideological battle between communism and capitalism.

Between 1947 and 1991, the United States engaged in the Cold War with the Union of Soviet Socialist Republics (USSR). While neither country officially declared war on the other, this conflict involved immense military build ups from both countries, massive espionage efforts, and the use of proxy powers to fight proxy wars against each other. Above all else, the ideological battle between communism and capitalism rested at the heart of the Cold War. Domestically, the Cold War involved large amounts of government interference in labor unions, socialist political parties, and anything else that the government deemed communist and therefore anti-patriotic. The primary source of domestic interference from the government came from the Central Intelligence Agency (CIA) and their various programs designed to eradicate the global spread of communism. The CIA created one of these programs, MK-ULTRA, to find ways to control the human brain, a response to Soviet advances in the field. It was one of the most classified and outlandish projects of the Cold War, revealed to the public in 1974 by the New York Times. However, upon the project's release to the public, there was no major revelation, protests, or societal pushback. Despite the fact that scandals of similar scale had inflicted significant change on the American public's perception and trust in government, MK-ULTRA instead caused only change in the government, and was discovered solely due to some investigative journalism. This is due to the other major breaches of trust the American government committed at the same time, namely the war in Vietnam and the Watergate scandal. This overlook tragically undermines the CIA's gross abuses of power and violations of globally recognized standards, along with the horrific mistreatment of patients in MK-ULTRA. During World War II, the United States government created the Office of Strategic Services (OSS) to conduct espionage projects for all branches of the military, often acting behind enemy lines to sabotage supply lines, support resistance movements, and launch counter-propaganda efforts. Shortly after the war, the National Security Act of 1947 converted the OSS into a new agency, the Central Intelligence Agency (CIA); this new agency now conducted its missions outside of the military, acting on its own. During the Cold

War, the CIA became an essential component of America's fight against communism, sending agents across the globe to conduct propaganda campaigns, meddle in foreign elections, and even attempt to assassinate global leaders. The Agency did not solely constitute espionage agents; they also had several departments with experts and experimenters that worked on programs like MK-ULTRA to aid the fight against the USSR and its dreaded communism.

After the end of the Korean war, which lasted from 1950 to 1953, American prisoners of war (POWs) returning home often acted in a way that directly contradicted their beliefs and patriotism before their capture. According to John Marks in his well known nonfiction *The Search for the Manchurian Candidate*, "by the end of the Korean War, 70 percent of the 7,190 U.S. prisoners held in China had either made confessions or signed petitions calling for an end to the American war effort in Asia," suggesting that some major political and ideological change had taken place in the minds of these POWs, a change not unnoticed by the United States government and its new espionage agency. Some of these confessions professed that the United States had dropped bombs containing cholera, the black plague, and various other infectious diseases (these allegations have never since been proven by any global agency). While the US government regarded these confessions as forcibly exacted lies, they were extremely concerned about the method by which the North Koreans and other communists had proliferated these confessions from such able-bodied young men. When returning home, POWs spouted anti-American, anti-capitalist propaganda (using phrasing similar to Soviet officials at the time), and often found themselves unable to recall key events in their lives. These details led the US government and the CIA to believe that the Soviets had developed a method of controlling the human mind as part of their military build up. As a direct response to the possible Soviet advances, the CIA launched project MK-ULTRA in 1953 to develop their own mind control methods.

While the idea of controlling the mind was novel to the Agency, the idea of controlling the human mind was not entirely new to the US government. Late OSS projects used data taken from Nazi concentration camps like Dachau, and the discovery of lysergic acid diethylamide (LSD) by Swiss chemist Albert Hoffman to work on the development of a drug that would force its taker to speak the truth. MK-ULTRA (a general term that referred to 159 specific sub projects) on the other hand, sought to totally control a person's behavior through conditioning their mind. While, according to the Harvard Kennedy Policy Center, "dosing subjects with LSD appears to have been the main method designated for the purpose of mind control," the Agency tried many different methods to control be-

havior. For example, subprojects investigated how to control the mind through hypnosis, the use of repeated tapes or records that played nonstop along the subjects bedside, and through drugs that could force the candidate to perform a specific action against their will. The specific goal of controlling the mind for the CIA was to create a perfect “Manchurian Candidate,” a term coined in 1959 by author Richard Condon in his book *The Manchurian Candidate*, where a well-known American is brainwashed by communists into becoming an assassin for a conspiracy. The CIA scoured every means available for ways to condition one’s mind into unwittingly or unwillingly performing specific actions, yet they also wanted the candidate to be untraceable back to them; subproject 7 was especially designed for this purpose, as it sought to discredit the actions or mental competence of a person through inducing memory loss and abnormal behaviors. Across all of the subprojects, the patient experience was frankly brutal, as many tests were conducted on already sick patients at mental institutions. CIA doctors told patients that the procedures would help their conditions, yet they failed to fully explain the tests, thus invalidating any consent the patients gave. Many of the experiments, especially the electroshock therapy, left patients with lifelong effects, predominantly post-traumatic stress disorder. Throughout the program’s operation, senior officials maintained the highest level of secrecy and informed very few people of its existence. Furthermore, almost nobody privy to the program knew about more than three to five sub projects, preventing them from exposing the larger program if they were to reveal parts to a news agency. Eventually, senior experimenters in the program terminated the program in 1964, fearful that the program could be discovered if the projects continued.

Despite this high level of secrecy, the New York Times caught wind of the program and published an article about the CIA’s furtive activities, leading to extensive congressional investigations into the CIA. The article alleged that the American government had conducted illegal spying on its citizens throughout the presidency of Richard Nixon. Unfortunately, due to the destruction of almost all of the files in 1973 (amid the chaos of the Watergate scandal, CIA director Richard Helms personally ordered the destruction of all records relating to MK-ULTRA programs), the investigation that followed used only files that had been discovered after a Freedom of Information Act request filed by the Times found 17,000 MK-ULTRA files that survived the purge due to being misordered into financial records. Before its publication, no other news source, government organization, or political figure had come this close to discovering the true depths of the CIA’s experimentation in the 1950s and 1960s. The article alleges that the CIA had conducted a series

of highly classified programs that were “prohibited by law,” explaining the importance of spreading awareness around the violation of the congressional checks and balances. The article also goes on to mention that the president, Richard Nixon, had not been informed of the existence of any of the CIA’s classified projects, stating that a CIA official “who was [directly] involved in the initial C.I.A. inquiry last year,” alleged that the previous investigators “were unable to learn what Mr. Nixon knew, if anything,” which signalled the program’s illegitimacy to Congress. Upon its publication, this article prompted Congress to examine the CIA’s historic abuses of power throughout the Cold War, allowing the government to implement safeguards to ensure against programs like MK-ULTRA and ensure that the due persons and congressional bodies are informed of their existence.

Due to the concerning secrecy of the program when it was operational, MK-ULTRA forced the American government to hold intelligence agencies more accountable upon its revelation. Once the program had been discovered through the 17,000 misfiled records reported by the New York Times, two separate federal investigations were launched immediately, examining how the project was handled, and determining if they violated any laws. In opening remarks, the Church committee stated that the goal of the investigation was to examine “past events in order to better understand what statutes and other guidelines might be necessary to prevent the recurrence of such abuses in the future,” meaning that the primary objective of the investigation was to glean lessons from the CIA’s historic abuse of power so that the Agency could be effectively restrained in the future. After a thorough investigation of the remaining files and dozens of witness testimonies, the Church committee delivered the following statement:

There is no evidence that either the executive branch or Congress were ever informed of [the projects]. The highly compartmented nature of these programs may be explained in part by an observation made by the CIA Inspector General that, “the knowledge that the Agency is engaging in unethical and illicit activities would have serious repercussions in political and diplomatic circles and would be detrimental to the accomplishment of its missions.

The committee’s finding that neither the executive branch nor the legislature had been informed of the activities illuminates the true illegitimacy of the program’s secrecy from its very inception. Most importantly, however, the finding describes how the Central Intelligence Agency knew that the MK-ULTRA program was illegally executed and how it would be shut down if people or governments discovered the contents of the program, and despite the knowledge that it could harm political and diplomatic relationships if exposed,

the program still operated until 1964. Once the Church committee reported their finding that the CIA had failed to inform the proper governmental bodies of their operations, president Gerald Ford issued an executive order that reminded all intelligence agencies—not only the CIA—in the United States that they had to properly inform other branches of the government of their work to ensure that no abuses of power occurred. In a section of the executive order titled “Congressional Oversight,” Ford reminds the directors of intelligence agencies of their duty to follow federal law:

The duties and responsibilities of the Director of Central Intelligence and the heads of other departments, agencies, and entities engaged in intelligence activities to cooperate with the Congress in the conduct of its responsibilities for oversight of intelligence activities shall be as provided in title 50, United States Code, section 413.

This section clarifies that all intelligence agencies, especially the CIA, must follow title 50, United States Code, section 413, which disallows federal agencies from interfering with regular political processes. This clarification was critical, as the MK-ULTRA program aimed to develop assassins that could kill anyone the CIA deemed a communist or threat to capitalism, including domestic politicians. Furthermore, the idea that the CIA must work in tandem with Congress, rather than behind its back, while seemingly obvious now, was a complete reversal of the Agency’s policy on secrecy, a policy that had lasted for the entirety of the CIA’s thirty years in operation. This change specifically emphasizes how drastically MK-ULTRA affected the government: it caused a multi-million dollar government agency with agents and experimenters across the globe to completely shift its policies to respect the existing law. However, while the MK-ULTRA projects helped push the federal government, most of the American public was too distracted to promote further reform.

For the public and experts alike, the American military’s outlandish operations throughout the Cold War offered plenty of room for imagination, yet when the government revealed projects such as MK-ULTRA, the public instead focused on greater scandals at the time, namely the war in Vietnam and the Watergate scandal. In an article published by the National Library of Medicine, psychiatrist Charlie Williams argues that the covert nature of mind control programs during the Cold War required less “dealing with scientific ‘facts,’” rather than the “diverse imaginary” that people engaged in when talking about government mind control projects. Yet, despite this paranoia that infected conversation nationwide, there was no major push for reform from the people, only in Congress. However, this lack in public reaction is largely due to the massive publicity given to the war in Vietnam and the Watergate scandal. For example, the war in Vietnam dominated

headlines from when the United States invaded Vietnam in 1955, to the total withdrawal of American soldiers in 1975; approval ratings of the war reached as low as 32% in 1968, and protests erupted across the country on a scale previously unheard of. This massive scale of public opinion against American involvement in Vietnam caused a significant erosion in the American public's trust in the government once the people observed that the government was no longer a reflection of the will of the people. According to an opinion editorial published in the New York Times written by Karl Marlantes, a veteran from the war, "Vietnam changed us as a country," he said, "it made us cynical and distrustful of our institutions, especially of government," emphasizing the loss in trust caused by the government's choice to not listen to its constituents. This distrust in government in the 1970s, along with MK-ULTRA's seeming lack of publicity, can also be attributed to the Watergate scandal, the term used to refer to the scandal between 1972 and 1974 when the Republican party tried to cover up the fact that six masked, gloved men had broken into the Democratic Party National Committee headquarters in the Watergate complex to plant listening devices. The goal of the break-in was to aid the reelection of republican Richard Nixon in the 1972 election, yet the six men who tried to break in were apprehended, and once news of the story reached president Nixon, a massive cover up of the break-in ensued. However, news of the break-in eventually reached the press, and the story controlled headlines on newspapers like The New York Times, and The Washington Post for months until Nixon eventually resigned in 1974. Between the two major scandals, media coverage around MK-ULTRA was largely masked.

Throughout their existence, the MK-ULTRA projects had a significant impact on thousands of Americans nationwide, as many test subjects were not given the full understanding of what the testing entailed. Along with being morally ambiguous, the program violated the fourth Geneva convention, the Nuremberg code, and caused decades of trauma to patients. The CIA's experimentation in the 1950s and 1960s directly violated rule 92 of the fourth Geneva convention, which states that "scientific experiments or any other medical procedure not indicated by the state of health of the person concerned and not consistent with generally accepted medical standards are prohibited," this complete and utter disregard for the global standard of the treatment was one of many examples of the CIA's drastic effort to expand its military capabilities with total disregard for all other preceding priorities, such as the treatment of civilians and test subjects. Along with the fourth Geneva convention, the MK-ULTRA experimentation also violated the Nuremberg code, which was written after the atrocities of the Holocaust and outlined that full, voluntary

consent must be given for any human testing to be legal. The Nuremberg trials, of which all of the judges were American, convicted seven German scientists of crimes against humanity and sentenced them to death, and the code was written by several Americans and backed by the American government. Thus, according to John Marks, “the U.S. government put its full moral force behind the idea that there were limits on what scientists could do to human subjects, even when a country’s security was thought to hang in the balance.” This illuminates the revelation that the CIA truly had no moral excuse for these violations, no matter how important they believed mind control was to the national defense or Cold War competition.

However, the true heartbreak of MK-ULTRA rested not in the violation of code, but rather rested in the stories of people whose lives were forever shaken by the American government. Heartbreakingly so, one of the CIA’s longest running experiments took place at the Allan Memorial hospital in Montreal, Canada, where psychiatric patients were offered treatment by world-renowned psychiatrist Donald Cameron, only to find themselves subject to the whims of the Central Intelligence Agency and its twisted experimenters. In the hospital, patients like Velma Orlikow (who came to the hospital for help with her diagnosed postpartum depression) underwent electroshock therapy, LSD overdoses, and dozens of other tests to see how their minds could be contorted and controlled. The American government never tried to compensate her, recognize the injustice, or even recognize that she had been a part of MK-ULTRA. Despite a decade of testing, millions of dollars in funding, 159 subprojects, and thousands of human test subjects, the program never actually found a method of truly controlling the human mind. Instead, it left its test subjects feeling unrecognized by the government and the entire media for decades afterwards.

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WHY DON'T WE HAVE NATIONAL HEALTHCARE?

WILLIAM LARA MCCANNON

Milton Academy '28

Millions of our citizens do not now have a full measure of opportunity to achieve and enjoy good health. Millions do not now have protection or security against the economic effects of sickness. The time has arrived for action to help them attain that opportunity and that protection.

– Harry S. Truman, remarks to Congress, 1945

* * *

Seven months after adopting the presidency on April 12th, 1945, Harry S. Truman proposed his universal healthcare insurance program. Due to the status quo, his plan failed spectacularly. As president, Truman fiercely advocated for improving general welfare, a belief outlined under five pillars: increasing physician retention in rural communities, improving maternal and child care, bolstering investment in medical research and education, addressing the exorbitant cost of medical care, and alleviating the financial loss incurred by illness. Truman hoped that his national healthcare plan, which covered pillars four and five, would mean that “whether or not patients get the services they need would not depend on how much they can afford to pay at the time.” The issue of affordability was supremely relevant; at the time, healthcare was limited to either the richest, due to the high out-of-pocket costs, or to the poorest, who relied on charity care for treatment, leaving the middle class uncovered. Truman vowed to change this system, “trying to fix it so the people in the middle income bracket can live as long as the very rich and very poor.” Unfortunately for Truman, the state of affairs in the United States obstructed his intended progress. The South’s Jim Crow segregationist system, the rising fear of communism, and a belligerent American Medical Association (AMA), unaccustomed to government intervention, created a feedback loop that degraded the public support for the national system, ultimately causing its demise. While Truman’s plan enabled the implementation of Medi-

care and Medicaid in 1965 during Lyndon B. Johnson's presidency, its failure encouraged President Johnson to focus on charitable policy which avoided addressing the middle class and destroyed the possibility of creating social service programs in America.

The end of World War II, on September 2nd, 1945, spurred the beginning of a tumultuous period for America that was defined by the ambiguity between facism, communism, and democracy. The Third Reich was itself a paradox. On the one hand, the German democratic state's abrupt transformation into a fascist regime – emblemized by the Holocaust's killing of more than six million innocents – exposed the world to the dangers of government overreach and unchecked prejudice. On the other hand, it established social services: old age insurance, educational reforms, and public health programs. Now, for the first time, people questioned the validity of popular pseudo-sciences, such as Social Darwinism, which were the basis for racial discrimination. As Ruth Benedict put it in her book, *Race and Racism*, racism is “a travesty of scientific knowledge,” and, out of the embers of the war, communism emerged as an appealing alternative to the crushing individualism and discrimination of capitalism. “Communism is completed naturalism is humanism and as completed humanism is naturalism,” said Karl Marx, highlighting communism's aim to abolish class divisions and establish a fundamentally fair, human society. The Soviet Union, ruled with Joseph Stalin's iron fist, became the only nation comparable in military might, ideological prowess, and international authority to the United States. Their competition for economic and social superiority set the stage for the Cold War. In response, America—threatened by Russia's zealous promotion of their communist agenda by influencing foreign affairs—created the Truman Doctrine in 1947. The United States designed the policy to contain the spread of communism by directly supporting “free peoples who are resisting attempted subjugation...by outside pressures,” intertwining the two powers in a “Great Power Conflict” that sought ideological domination. The Cold War motivated Senator Joseph McCarthy's (R-WI) anti-communist crusade, creating a “Red Scare” in which America was gripped by the fear of communism. Locked in a geopolitical battle of principle, the US was put under a spotlight; as Truman put it, “the free peoples of the world look to us for support in maintaining their freedoms.”

The establishment of the National Health Service (NHS) in the United Kingdom exemplified the circumstantial reasons why universal healthcare failed in the US but succeeded in Britain. The end of WWII left England devastated: millions of homes damaged, critical infrastructure destroyed, rationing that continued even post-war, and economic depression that crippled the nation. The harsh circumstances catalysed a change in Brit-

ish thinking. Much like how Franklin D. Roosevelt (FDR) promoted his “four essential human freedoms”—‘freedom of speech, freedom of worship, freedom from want, and freedom from fear’—Britain broadcasted its mission to tackle the ‘Five Giants’: “Want, Disease, Ignorance, Squalor and Idleness.” Suddenly, national healthcare became morally imperative. The post-war enlightenment prompted scrutiny of human rights in the United Kingdom. In his 1952 book *In Place of Fear*, United Kingdom Minister of Health Aneurin Bevan declared that “no society can legitimately call itself civilized if a sick person is denied medical aid because of lack of means,” commentary that highlighted England’s progressive political ideology.

As such, the success of the NHS establishment in 1948 is largely due to the social, economic, and political environment of the country at the time. The British Medical Association “was psycho-logically prepared for universal health care,” having provided for half the population under a plan for low-income individuals 36 years beforehand. Further, by covering 85% of the costs with general revenue, the plan left the taxpayers relatively unaffected. Britain’s government “exercise[d] stronger control over details,” as it was not troubled with maintaining states’ rights. Finally, the UK’s homogeny – only “5.5 percent of the population” was part of “ethnic minorities” – meant that the nation lacked racial tension. This combination of factors led to the plan’s “acceptance by all leading politicians in this country,” as noted former-PM Attlee. Britain succeeded because the people needed National Healthcare: the social deprivation emphasized the importance of healthcare as a human right, meanwhile Britain’s political structure let the NHS pass easily. Yet for every reason the UK triumphed, Truman was hindered by an onslaught of opposition that destroyed any hope for universal healthcare in America.

Segregation’s entrenchment in Southern society could never coexist with universal healthcare; success meant the destruction of a Jim Crow system that had thrived for centuries. Truman’s point of failure was the South’s silver bullet: the United States’ sacred obligation to ‘states’ rights.’ The 1896 Supreme Court case *Plessy v. Ferguson* heralded an era of condoned white superiority by stating that “if one race be inferior to the other socially, the Constitution of the United States cannot put them upon the same plane.” This racial divide manifested itself in Southern segregation, where all “public spaces and entertainment venues” remained divided. Although enforced by consistent violence—“the southern states account[ed] for nine-tenths of the lynchings,” the return of over 1.2 million African-American GIs caused a resurgence in brutality. However, the issue began earlier. Passed in 1935, FDR’s Social Security Act, among other benefits, provided old age insur-

ance. Fearing Black's would move away from lower-paying jobs, Southern Democrats, exercising their Congressional power, excluded agricultural laborers and domestic servants – 60% of the Black workforce – from the Act. Because the idea of an empowered Black working-class scared Southerners, the GI Bill, which offered free college tuition, loan assistance, unemployment insurance and more, caused “many whites [to fear] that returning Black veterans would upset the racial status quo.” In addition to resurging violence, the GI Bill's implementation being delegated to states allowed Southerners to deny Blacks their benefits. Whites built “homes with racially restrictive covenants ... a practice known as exclusionary zoning,” which kept Blacks out of favorable neighborhoods, and incidentally, meant that “factories, oil refineries, municipal dumps, and the municipal incinerator [ended up] on blocks with Black residences.” So given that the New Orleans City Commission claimed “poor health conditions go hand in hand with poor housing facilities,” being Black in the '30s and '40s was fraught with danger: The African-American experience resulted in 60% of insurance companies denying them coverage, ironically, citing higher risk. The result was a wealth ratio of eight to one, whites to Blacks, in 1940. Even though Black soldiers were promised protections, the federalist system preserved Jim Crow by delegating power to state legislatures, a measure the South abused. So when Truman proposed his national healthcare plan, Southern delegations responded with the force of the times.

The GI Bill and Executive Order 9981's enactment left Congress feeling that increased government involvement threatened federalism; as a successor to these actions, Truman's healthcare proposition – also known as the Wagner-Murray-Dingell bill – strained existing racial and intragovernmental tension, provoking fierce bipartisan opposition. Passed by Truman in 1948, Executive Order 9981, as described by *Ebony Magazine*, was the “swiftest and most amazing upset of racial policy in the history of the U.S. military.” Truman's action came in response to America's international humiliation; led by W.E.B DuBois, the NAACP brought forth to the recently-established UN its Appeal to the World, a testimony to the United States' paradox:

a great nation, which today ought to be in the forefront of the march toward peace and democracy, finds itself continuously making common cause with race-hate, prejudiced exploitation and oppression of the common man. Its high and noble words are turned against it, because they are contradicted in every syllable by the treatment of the American Negro for three hundred and twenty-eight years.

While more symbolic than effective, Truman, with the stroke of his pen, had disrupted

four centuries' worth of social norms; when he proposed his healthcare plan, it represented executive overreach that attacked both Republican and the Southern Democratic ideologies. The fiscally conservative Republicans disliked Truman's financing the system with 3% "contributions," as they believed "taxes are taxes." They believed that Truman's plan was the last domino in a chain of prior legislation enacted that imposed the government on individual liberties. Southern Democrats agreed as well, given how dramatically these executive orders – such as E.O. 9981 and the GI Bill – threatened to change the very fabric of Jim Crow; so because Truman's healthcare plan would have desegregated the hospital system, it was a life-or-death situation for Southern Democrats. The status of the South's hospital structure illustrates the drastic change Southern Democrats feared.

The South detested Truman's healthcare policy because it meant the reversal of a heavily segregated healthcare system, resulting in a disintegration of Jim Crow laws. The South had the worst healthcare system in America; in 1940, Surgeon General Thomas Parran called the South "[t]he number one health problem of the Nation;" yet for Black Americans, the situation was much worse. Only 6% of Southern Hospitals were fully integrated while 47% allowed access to segregated wards – often in basements or attics – and 31% denied admission outright. The rest, all-Black hospitals, were limited in number and drained in resources: "In sixteen southern states 9.7 million African Americans were served by 79 black hospitals, most of which were unaccredited, underequipped, and struggling to remain open." This utter lack of adequate facilities caused "the urban black death rate [to be] 95% higher than that of the urban white population." Truman's statement, in which he details that "the benefits of modern medical science have not been enjoyed by our citizens with any degree of equality...unless government is bold enough to do something about it," indirectly targets Southern segregation as an issue for governmental reform. Therefore, a byproduct of affirming national healthcare would result in tangible, legal "equality": true integration through the destruction of Plessy v. Ferguson segregation. So while Southern whites and Blacks both endured health issues, according to Paul Krugman, "[k]eeping Black people out of white hospitals was more important to Southern politicians than providing poor whites with the means to get medical treatment." To fix this problem while simultaneously protecting Jim Crow, Congress employed the Hill-Burton Act.

Passed in 1946, the Hill-Burton Act, which "launched the Nation on the most comprehensive hospital and public health construction program ever undertaken," was a bipartisan effort to circumvent the Wagner-Murray-Dingell bill. The Hill-Burton Act sought to appease the public, who supported Truman's plan. In 1945, "Gallup found 59%

of Americans... favored the plan,” suggesting dissatisfaction with the current healthcare system. The Republican rationale, led by Harold Burton (R-OH), addressed the population’s distaste: the sparsity of hospital beds. The Southern Democratic focus, championed by Lister Hill (D-AL), fiercely advocated for the autonomy of state legislatures “to set policy without federal interference.” Yet, most interestingly, the Act was the only 20th century legislation to include a segregation clause, specifying “that discrimination on the basis of race was acceptable if there was ‘equitable provision...for each such group.’” Southern Democrats had bypassed Truman’s plan, bolstering the US’ healthcare system while preserving Jim Crow. The South put the segregation clause to good use: “65/67 Alabama counties used Hill-Burton money to build hospitals that were segregated.” Furthermore, even though “20 percent of projects aided teaching hospitals, including the burgeoning new academic medical centers,” these universities were segregated, which kept physician education in Black communities stagnant. But even with separate wards and doctoral schools, the ingeniousness of the Hill-Burton Act was that it actually benefited the Southern Black population: “Southerners of both races, but blacks particularly, began to enjoy an access to modern hospital care that they had never known before.” The increased access to care created a schism in the progressive Black diaspora, which had “long engaged in a dialectic between separatism and integrationism.” Some Blacks supported the Act’s benefit to African-American health regardless of segregation, while others, notably the National Medical Association—the Black alternative to the AMA—viewed it as a setback in the fight for integration. The Hill-Burton Act, in addition to alleviating the internal pressures, had an international impact, displaying America’s commitment to humanity which improved the US public image, critical during the Cold War. The Hill-Burton Act also allowed Congress to engage with public support for improved healthcare while simultaneously enforcing segregation in the South and dividing the Black opinion.

The AMA—of which 75% of physicians were members—disapproved of Truman’s plan because they perceived it as a threat to physician autonomy. Even though Truman emphasized repeatedly that “Socialized medicine means that all doctors work as employees of government...[but] No such system is here proposed,” more than 70% of physicians opposed the plan on the basis of losing physician autonomy; and what is what doctors control best but who they chose to treat. The AMA, being itself ‘whites only,’ implies’ that desegregation would inhibit doctors from discriminating against patients based on race. In response, they launched a massive advertisement campaign to counter the proposal, using the nation’s fear of communism to its advantage.

Partnering with Whitaker and Baxter's (WB) Campaigns Incorporated, the AMA charged their physicians an extra \$25, spending \$1,500,000 on advertisement in 1945 alone. AMA-disseminated pamphlets focused on universal healthcare's link to socialist and fascist regimes. One pamphlet asked: "Would socialized medicine lead to socialization of other phases of life? Lenin thought so. He declared socialized medicine is the keystone to the arch of the socialist state." Supporting the AMA's stance was that Hitler had implemented national healthcare in Germany as well: Friederich Hayek, an Austrian economist and philosopher, asserted that "by giving the government unlimited powers...a democracy may set up the most complete despotism imaginable." According to Hayek's philosophy, not only was Truman's plan purportedly communist, but a step towards totalitarianism; and given that Americans were particularly sensitized to issues surrounding their freedoms, reeling from the end of the deadly World War, every government action was scrutinized tenfold. The AMA, both partaking in and using public fear, published numerous pamphlets and cartoons that ingrained in American minds that they must choose "The American Way" over Truman's "socialized medicine" (see figure 1). By shifting the rhetoric and establishing the narrative that single-payer insurance was "American," the AMA thought it had silenced the issue...but Truman's massive presidential upset in 1948 (see figure 2), in which he defied all odds to beat Thomas Dewey, resparked the national healthcare debate.

The AMA deemed Truman's reelection an "Armageddon Moment" because of the NHS' precedent-setting establishment, the Democratic majority in Congress, and national healthcare's still high approval rate. In response, AMA quickly mobilized and partnered with over 1,800 organizations to use the status quo to appeal to the public. One strategy involved redoubling efforts to frame Truman's plan as communist. Comics (see figure 3) forced a narrative in which national healthcare resulted in American socialism. Senator Taft (R-OH), among other Congressmen, also cited communism: it is "the most socialistic measure this Congress has ever had before it." The threat of communism was convenient for racists, too, as for Black people. One person noted that "[to speak] out forcefully for civil rights was to risk being branded a 'Commie.'"

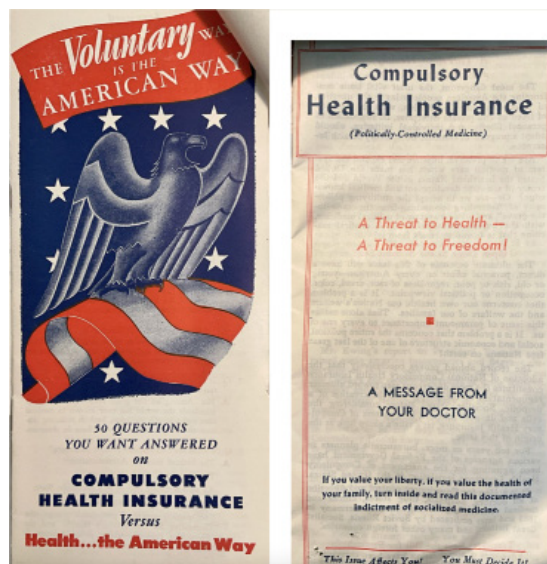
The AMA also targeted the bill's funding approach, aligning with Republicans. Pamphlets, (Figure 4), exaggerated the impact on the taxpayer. Furthermore, statements such as those of Elmer Henderson, the AMA's Chairman of the Board, who denounced the employer's necessity "to contribute exorbitant payroll taxes" of up to 10%, or the AMA's claim that "The cost of medical care...would be doubled and trebled by bureaucratic over-

head,” convinced the middle class that Truman’s plan was more financially burdensome than helpful to healthcare. The economic argument was buttressed by the rapid expansion of the private insurance industry. Because the 1942 and ‘43 rulings by the War Labor Board and IRS respectively offered tax breaks to companies, such as US Steel and General Motors, who provided healthcare benefits, access to health insurance grew rapidly; employers could compensate lower wages by offering ‘fringe benefits’ to attract labor. In fact, in Mr. Henderson’s same speech, he spotlighted that out of 151 million people, “55,000,000 Americans are protected...[and] 37,000,000 policy holders are insured against surgical or medical bills.” All told, the AMA’s advertisement campaign was responsible for a 20% increase in private healthcare insurance enrollment, whereby in 1950, the number of Americans with employer-coverage grew to 142 million from 21 million in 1940. Conversely, approval for Truman’s plan plummeted to just 24% in 1950, convinced by how critics negatively portrayed the plan in respect to the status quo.

World War II’s end harbored a resurgence of Jim Crow segregation, a fear of communism, and a political, economic, and racial landscape that proved too hostile for Truman’s universal healthcare plan. Between the emergence of communism that caused a national panic, and the strong executive presence in national policy which threatened the pre-existing racial constructs, Truman proposed his universal healthcare proposal came at the worst possible time. Republicans, who disliked the taxes; Southern Democrats, who wanted to preserve segregation; and the AMA, which wished to enforce physician autonomy, utilized the “Red Scare” to their advantage, framing national healthcare as “socialized medicine,” decimating public support. Truman’s plan failed, and while it paved the way for Lyndon B. Johnson’s passing of Medicare and Medicaid in 1965, its failure established that the US would never have social services. So while President Johnson’s calling Truman “the real daddy of Medicare,” may have seemed flattering, it actually meant the death of the middle class’ healthcare hopes. From 1950 to 1970, consumer prices had increased 61% while medical costs soared by 125%, so for the socially disadvantaged, the implementation of Medicaid and Medicare came at the perfect time: three years after their enactment, more than 20 million individuals enrolled in the program, highlighting the bill’s scope. But given its target audience was the poor and the elderly, Medicare and Medicaid were passed because they were charity programs. LBJ viewed himself as a “bookend” to a decades-long struggle commenced by FDR and continued by Truman to improve public health, but in reality, Medicare and Medicaid symbolized the death of any future social services as any program needed to be unequivocally charitable. Aid to the middle class would have result-

ed in suspicions of socialist ideology, like those perceived to be found in Truman's national healthcare proposal, and would terminate the plan immediately.

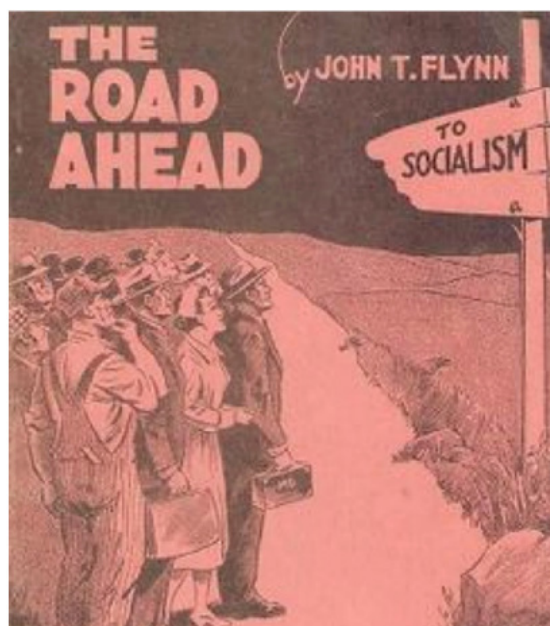
Appendix



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RECOGNITION ON HIS OWN TERMS: TRUMAN, AZEC, AND THE STATE OF ISRAEL

Changming Lucas Xia

Milton Academy '28

At 6:11 p.m. on May 14th, 1948, just eleven minutes after Ben-Gurion declared the State of Israel's independence, the White House published a statement recognizing the new Jewish state as de facto. The timing was exact. Days prior, Secretary of State George Marshall, an accomplished general in Truman's administration, clearly warned the president that recognizing Israel would mean a vote against Truman. Marshall's department as a whole was against the recognition. Arab nations threatened a third world war. Regardless, Truman signed. Contesting explanations are all insufficient, standalone: moral duty from the Holocaust, pressure from pro-Israel groups in the Oval Office, primarily the American Zionist Emergency Council (AZEC), or electoral schemes preceding the 1948 presidential elections. While each is partially true, none suffices to explain his decision. Harry S. Truman's recognition of Israel was not a submission to Rabbi Silver and AZEC's statehood campaign, but a strategic play of his own presidential power. Three forces converged on his decision: the AZEC lobby's structured campaign, a State Department working to reverse his foreign policy, and his own inherited moral standings set by Woodrow Wilson, evangelical upbringing, and post-Holocaust moral conviction. Truman, who had deliberately avoided commitment throughout 1946-47, took account of all those pressures and set his own terms on the decision, acting over explicit warnings from his own Secretary of State, George Marshall.

Even before President Harry S. Truman embarked on his White House political career, the gears sending Palestine into partition had been set into motion. In 1917, Arthur Balfour wrote to Lord Rothschild declaring British endorsement of "a national home for the Jewish people ... in Palestine", a commitment backed by then-President Woodrow Wilson, establishing a precedent of American presidents acting in accordance with the ambitions of Zionist leaders – at the time Chaim Weizmann and Ben-Gurion – an expectation Truman directly inherits. While in 1922, the Churchill White Paper restated British dedication, it noted that calling for legislative action towards establishing the state while considering Arab displacement. This equivocation would define global political action for

the following two decades. By 1942, with the Holocaust underway, world Zionist leaders assembled in New York for the Biltmore Conference, concretizing their demands for “the gates of Palestine be opened ... and that Palestine be established as a Jewish Commonwealth integrated in the structure of the new democratic world.” Ben-Gurion provocatively hoped the horrors of the Holocaust would become a “fertile force” for Zionism, pressuring the inevitable into creation. That pressure cohered on November 29, 1947, when the UNGA – and the United States, among many – voted in favor of Resolution 181(II), partitioning Palestine into two distinct Jewish and Arab states, marking America’s vote as formal support of a Jewish state half a year before Truman recognised Israel.

Truman did not have the luxury to approach the Palestine question on a blank slate. The circumstances that he inherited – presidential precedent, his evangelical Christian upbringing, and the moral crisis of the Holocaust – made neutrality impossible. President Wilson’s tradition of sympathy from the Oval Office towards advocates of Jewish statehood was reinforced by Louis Brandeis, who had implemented pro-Zionist sentiments within the highest echelons of American politics, long before Truman engaged in politics. His religious background furthered the biases he inherited; “President Harry Truman was sympathetic to Zionism because of his evangelical Christian upbringing”. This associated him with the broader cultural movement “improving” the image of American Jews from “outsiders” to “insiders” through Biblical texts and Christian Zionism. Additionally, the Holocaust gave a second, more policy-based motive, honed by the 1945 Harrison Report, which found that “as matters now stand, we appear to be treating the Jews as Nazis treated them”. Forced to face these startling findings, Truman declared the DP crisis an “American problem,” involving the United States directly in the Palestine question and concurrently triggering a State Department deeply concerned with the foreign ramifications of that statement. These inherited convictions set the baseline for his morals, but were also the most politically tested point in his presidency.

In the two years preceding recognition, the pro-Zionist lobby launched the most sustained pressure Truman received from any constituency, but Truman deliberately allowed that pressure so that he could resist it, not submit. Silver and AZEC used newspaper advertisements, petition drives, mass rallies, and the implicit threat of Jewish vote in swing cities to overwhelm Truman, leveraging the immense magnitude to force his attention. By early 1948, the number of advertisements and letters sent to the White House was simply unavoidable. “The pro-Zionist lobby (i.e., AZEC) truly came into its own during the Truman presidency”, and managed to convince “a substantial number of citizens and leaders

to join their lobbying efforts and win support from national and local politicians.” Using AZEC’s connections across many government branches, Silver used the Jewish bloc as electoral leverage in the 1948 presidential elections. Considering Truman’s unstable campaign even as the incumbent president, he could not bear that. Truman himself acknowledged the restlessness of this campaign in a correspondence to Congressman Klein: “I don’t think there has ever been any more lobbying and pulling and hauling than has been carried on by the Jews in this Palestine difficulty with which we have been faced.” Contrastingly, his reflection in his *Memoirs* six years later indicates a divergent narrative, saying that the “persistence of a few of the extreme Zionist leaders — actuated by political motives and engaging in political threats — disturbed and annoyed” him. Truman’s frustration was mainly directed at Rabbi Silver and the AZEC leadership, whose aggressive tactics solidified his determination to act on his own terms. However, the pattern of registering pressure without submitting to it first emerges to the public a year before recognition.

On the eve of Yom Kippur 1946, Truman issued a statement strongly supporting the admission of 100,000 displaced Jews into Palestine, and “publicly lent his backing to the creation of a “viable” Jewish state in Palestine, the most pro-Zionist statement ever made by a president.” While on the surface, it sounds like a pro-Zionist comment, Truman withheld any concrete commitments to the cause, a trait that would characterize his behavior through 1947. Considering that it was issued just before a midterm election cycle where Jewish votes in major metropolitan cities could easily sway results, this was not the electoral lifeline Truman was looking for. The Democrats lost control of both the House and the Senate. Yet, Truman himself reaped the benefits with minimal commitments, securing Jewish-American amiability for the 1948 elections. This transactional sentiment he conveys with the American Jewry clearly shows in his correspondence with Congressman Klein, when Truman states that he had “no objection to their lobbying – neither [has he] any objection to the Arabs doing so if they feel like it, but, in neither case, does it affect [his] decisions or judgement.” The Yom Kippur statement was not going towards recognition, and was instead Truman’s maneuver, attempting to buy time while he waited for a situation that would let him act on his own terms. But public deviation alone could not answer the pressure he faced from within his administration, from the people who reached him daily.

While the external pressure campaign launched by organizations like AZEC meaningfully shaped Truman’s thoughts on the Palestine question, more important were the Jewish connections within it. Inside the White House, a small circle of pro-Zionist

advisors held daily access to Truman and could reformulate Palestine as a moral question, circumventing the State Department without forcing Truman to overrule his diplomats in public or cause scandals. The three figures with such internal direct access to Truman – namely David Niles, Clark Clifford, and Max Lowenthal – were so influential that Loy Henderson “claimed to have known in advance that every memorandum he sent to the White House would find its way immediately through Niles to the Zionists,” confirming the existence of these insiders acting as conduits into the Oval Office. Crucially, these conduits were not simply bringing in demands for Jewish statehood, but also establishing the Palestine question as a moral one, giving Truman political reasons, often under the guise of a humanitarian one. The Weizmann meeting illustrates this perfectly: Chaim Weizmann, the “spiritual” leader of the Zionist movement, secured a private audience with Truman through Niles and persuaded Truman to keep the Negev desert for the Jews. Without issuing direct instructions, Truman made it plain to Hilldring. Nothing should be done to “upset the apple cart,” Truman admonished. Personal connections deepened the network; Eddie Jacobson, Truman’s former business partner, “did not belong to any Zionist organization, but he shared the dream of a national homeland and wanted to be helpful in the cause ... eventually as the quasi ambassador of the new state of Israel.” Truman himself understood this connection was created, and “was obliged to maneuver between a growing, aggressive Zionist lobby allied with his own White House advisors and a State Department which was unequivocally opposed to Zionism.” The network of Jewish-aligned White House advisors – Niles, Clifford, and Lowenthal – proved to be some of the most influential instruments in advancing the cause of Jewish statehood, ensuring that the arguments reached Truman quickly and were framed in a favourable light. While the insiders were winning their moral arguments within the Oval Office, the State Department’s opposition was concretizing around geopolitical concerns.

Much of the State Department’s opposition to the partition lay within the ties and dependencies Americans had in conjunction with the Arab threats of military and oil sanctions. The Arab Higher Committee had made itself clear, stating that “any attempt to impose a solution contrary to the Arabs’ birthright will lead to trouble, bloodshed, and probably a third world war.” Considering the repercussions American foreign policy faced after World War II, even the threat of another global conflict to that scale was unacceptable. King ‘Abd al-Aziz of Saudi Arabia escalated the tension, menacing war against the United States should it deploy forces in Palestine to support Jewish immigration, whilst simultaneously threatening oil sanctions against American oil interests in the region, namely AR-

AMCO. The State Department, spearheaded by Marshall, Henderson, and Lovett, immediately saw these threats as a validation of its concerns. Henderson regarded the partition as “a recipe for war and, in the event of U.S. support for partition, a guarantor of ‘long-term Arab hostility’”; considering the previous mentions of economic sanctions, the department saw an unyielding case against recognition.

Truman was unfazed. When Secretary of Defense James Forrestal said that the U.S. could not afford to lose Saudi Arabian oil, Truman snapped that he would not act based on oil but on “what is right.” The bluntness was intentional. His private correspondence with Jacobson in February of 1948 reveals a president frustrated equally by both sides of the pressure, noting that “the Jews are so emotional, and the Arabs are so difficult to talk with that it is almost impossible to get anything done.” Neither the Arab military provocations nor the oil threats shook Truman. His dismissal of the Arab threats adds to his documented frustration with AZEC’s tactics, suggesting that his recognition of Israel was not surrendering to AZEC, but him showing his presidential power over his split-minded administration and Marshall’s explicit warning.

After the UNGA voted 33-13-10, passing Resolution 181(II) and therefore the partition of Palestine into an Arab and Jewish state on November 29, 1947, the statehood advocacy and State Department opposition only increased; the former deliberately provoking Truman, the latter outright sabotaging him. Following the United States’ vote in favor, Silver quickly claimed credit, declaring that the AZEC had “marshaled our forces ... converged on the government and induced the president to assert the authority of his administration to overcome the negative attitude of the State Department.” Yet, behind Silver’s boisterous celebration hid a provocation, one that cast the outcome of the vote as a submission to AZEC’s demands, an implication Truman resented deeply, and steeled Truman’s mind that whatever recognition he gave would be on his own terms, not AZEC’s.

While the vote appeared to represent a deeply rooted American stance, the State Department was already maneuvering to reverse its effects. Though to public perception, Truman’s support was “consistent with his earlier efforts to secure admission of Jewish DPs to Palestine,” while “the State Department pursued its policy, silently hoping that the UN would finally fail.” Just eighteen days after the UNGA vote, the State Department circulated an internal report recommending that “the United States should immediately announce that we have become convinced that the partition of Palestine is impossible of implementation and that the Palestine problem should therefore be referred back to a special session of the General Assembly to meet in a neutral country such as Switzerland.” This

report directly contradicted the vote the United States delegates had cast only a few weeks earlier. This covert opposition broke into the public on March 19, 1948, when US Senator Warren Austin addressed the Security Council, calling for “the immediate convening of a special session of the General Assembly to institute a temporary trusteeship for Palestine,” reversing American policy in full public view without Truman’s permission. This episode made it clear to Truman that his real opposition was not the lobby he was alleged to be serving but his own State Department acting against his policy, a confrontation Marshall could no longer delay.

Two days before Israel declared independence, the tensions between Truman and the State Department reached their apex. On May 12, 1948, Truman had a meeting in the Oval Office to resolve the recognition question, considering the expiration of the British Mandate on May 15th. Marshall and his undersecretary, Robert Lovett, came in prepared to argue for a delay, while Clifford came to advocate for immediate recognition. Marshall was visibly angered when he saw Clifford in the room. “Mr. President,” he said, “I thought this meeting was called to consider an important and complicated problem in foreign policy. I don’t even know why Clifford is here. He is a domestic adviser, and this is a foreign policy matter.” To Marshall, Clifford’s presence confirmed his suspicion that a decision had already been made on electoral grounds, and that Clifford’s advice was equivalent to “a transparent dodge to win a few votes” at the expense of “the great dignity of the office of the President.” In response, Marshall delivered the boldest claim ever directed at a sitting president, bluntly stating that “if the President were to follow Mr. Clifford’s advice” and “if in the elections [he] were to vote, [he] would vote against the President.” However, the confrontation did not end there. The day of the Israel’s declaration of independence, Lovett warned that recognition would cause “a tremendous reaction . . . in the Arab world,” and requested a single-day extension to notify American embassies across Arab countries. Without even referring the request to Truman, Clifford outright rejected the delay. Marshall, on his side, ultimately followed the president’s orders and proceeded with the recognition. He sent a telegram to London, crossing out the word “limited” from the recognition language, but his compliance could not erase what had happened. Truman overrode his own Secretary of State, resisted unprecedented threats in American foreign policy history, and proceeded with his own judgment.

When Truman famously gave Israel his formal recognition on May 14th, 1948, eleven minutes after its founding, the timing of his recognition revealed a man who had long been set on his decision. The most telling detail of this entire episode is his hand-

written alteration of the White House Draft Release. He crossed out “Jewish State” and instead wrote “State of Israel,” revealing intentionality, and changing it from a religious/ethnic name to a political entity with true sovereignty, showing that Truman recognized a country, not a movement. The recognition was intentionally confined. The White House statement read: “The United States recognizes the provisional government as the de facto authority of the new ~~[[strickethrough]]~~ Jewish state~~[[/strickethrough]]~~ State of Israel.” The legal distinction between de facto and de jure plays a crucial role in Truman’s statement. By recognizing Israel only as de facto, Truman deliberately left ambiguity on borders, the control of Jerusalem, and internal governance, refusing to hand Ben-Gurion’s provisional government a *carte blanche*. He enforced this restricted scope by imposing conditions on democratic elections, stating that “when a permanent government was elected in Israel, it would promptly be given de jure recognition.” Israel held those elections on January 25, 1949 and just six days later, the United States extended full diplomatic recognition: “The United States Government is therefore pleased to extend de jure recognition to the Government of Israel as of this date.” Truman structured recognition as a reward for democratic governance, not as a submission to pro-Zionist advocacy. Across the edited release, the deliberate de facto scope, the de jure condition tied to elections, and his verifiable rejection of lobbying throughout 1946-47, one pattern persists: Truman registered all external pressure – Silver, Marshall, the Arab states – to set his own terms.

Recognition of Israel underscored a turning point that had implications stretching far beyond May 14, 1948. Silver and AZEC, Marshall and the State Department, and Truman’s moral principles each hold their own parts of the truth. But when analysing them standalone, none account for Truman crossing out “Jewish State,” his deliberately limiting the scope of recognition to de facto, or his willingness to act in defiance of his own Secretary of State. The “constant barrage” – composed of Clifford, Niles, Lowenthal, and Jacobson – working alongside Silver and AZEC only steeled Truman’s resolve. The recognition of Israel was Truman strategically demonstrating his presidential power on his own terms, refusing to submit to one group of advocates.

Silver had long cast the UNGA partition as a triumph for the AZEC’s lobby, a characterization of Truman that easily adapted into the popular narrative, letting “group-think and confirmation bias” solidify into “consistent techniques in maintaining a pro-Zionist paradigm for the policy-making elites of the U.S. government.” Yet, when reflecting on presidential administrations and their relationship with Israel, the story is anything but uniform. In 1956, following the Suez crisis, Eisenhower forced Israel to withdraw from the

Sinai Peninsula by pressuring Ben-Gurion through the cutoff of American private financial support. In 1991, George H. W. Bush delayed \$10 billion in U.S. loan guarantees to pressure Israel into halting West Bank settlement construction and participating in the Madrid Peace Conference. In 2015, Obama argued with Prime Minister Netanyahu ardently over Iranian nuclear deals, and even abstained from the UNSC Resolution 2334 vote, flagging Israeli settlements in the West Bank as “flagrant violation under international law”. In 2018, Trump reversed the course, moving the U.S. embassy to Jerusalem, and signed a proclamation officially recognizing Israeli sovereignty over the Golan Heights after 50 years of U.S. policy viewing the area as occupied territory. Biden, in response to the October 7 attacks in 2023, called American support for Israel “rock solid and unwavering,” but then withheld heavy-bomb shipments bound for Israel. Each president has had their version of the three-way balance Truman first had: an organized lobby, administrative caution, and executive judgment, on his own terms. Recognition planted a seed for a durable partnership, not a *carte blanche*; one still shaped by the tensions Truman navigated in 1948.

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U.S. COVERT POLITICAL INTERVENTIONS IN CHILE FROM 1970-1973

Amy Khaing
Milton Academy '27

Chile's two chronologically successive presidents, Salvador Allende and Augusto Pinochet, embodied opposing political visions. Allende was the world's first democratically elected socialist president and sought to implement socialism in Chile through democratic reforms, while Pinochet was an anti-communist authoritarian ruler who established a 17-year dictatorship. Following Pinochet's coup d'état in 1973, his regime became responsible for more than 40,000 victims from torture, executions, detentions, and disappearances. The drastic political shift from democracy to authoritarianism was not solely the result of internal division but was also influenced by foreign interference, particularly from the United States. When Allende won the presidency on September 4, 1970, U.S. policymakers likely perceived his victory as a threat to hemispheric unity and the spread of Marxist ideology, which could be a major setback for America's power in global politics. Just eleven days after Allende's election, President Richard Nixon reportedly ordered officials to "overthrow Allende," initiating covert interventions funded by \$8 million to "bring him down." Although the United States publicly maintained a stance of neutrality, its covert political interventions during the three years of Allende's presidency destabilized democracy in Chile, creating a "coup climate" that helped lay the foundation for Augusto Pinochet's brutal dictatorship.

Fueled by the desire to preserve its geopolitical self-interest, the United States carried out covert political interventions, ranging from supporting anti-Allende propaganda to funding labor strikes, which contributed to social unrest during the three years of Allende's presidency. Before assuming office, Allende pledged to nationalize US-owned copper industries, indirectly challenging American economic dominance in Chile. Meanwhile, because Allende's election occurred amid the Cold War, Nixon perceived Allende not only as a domestic reformer but also as a potential ally of the Soviet Union who could expand socialist ideologies throughout the Western Hemisphere. Within two days of Allende's inauguration, Nixon convened the National Security Council to discuss ways to "bring about his downfall." Nixon's opposition to Allende's government transformed from polit-

ical anxiety into a series of calculated covert interventions after he convened the National Security Council on November 6, 1970. Initially, government officials from the council, including Secretary of State William Rogers and Secretary of Defense Melvin Laird, merely expressed their desires to 'bring [Allende] down.' However, under Henry Kissinger's explicit prodding to broaden the scope of covert operations, the council transformed rhetoric into action by drafting an eight-page "Covert Action Program for Chile" in mid-November. With a \$7 million operational budget, the program was designed by the CIA "in an effort to maximize pressure on the Allende government." The rapid transition, occurring within a month, in which the United States transitioned from an ideological containment to an active program, proved the calculated measures the United States took to destabilize Allende's government from the very beginning. The first major covert action occurred in September 1971, when the United States funded \$700,000 to channel "anti-Allende propaganda" in Chile's largest newspaper, the *El Mercurio*. By 1972, the newspaper was "publishing almost daily editorials criticizing the Allende Government," becoming the "loudest opposition voice" and guiding force in shaping Chilean public opinion against Allende. Simultaneously, the United States cut off economic aid, denied credits, and imposed an "invisible blockade" through U.S. commercial banks to tighten the economic "squeeze" on Chile. Amidst Allende's policies to reform the labor force, this intentional "squeeze" intensified economic pressure on Chilean workers, particularly those in the mining and transportation sectors. While the United States exacerbated political and economic tensions, Allende also faced shortcomings within his own policies. The March of the Empty Pots, a protest involving over ten thousand protestors, initially stemmed from the dissatisfaction with Allende's failure to support women's labor rights. However, his dissatisfaction was exacerbated by the US-funded "special propaganda campaigns," which sought to convince women that Allende's government would threaten their families' livelihoods. The protest thus reflected the broader dual dynamic, in which the United States magnified existing Chilean dissatisfaction with Allende's policy. By financing protests and amplifying political polarization, the United States fostered an atmosphere of economic chaos and social unrest. As *The New York Times* reported in 1974, the "CIA secretly financed Chilean labor union strikes for more than 18 months" before the coup. Several agencies later admitted that these covert interventions by the United States played "a significant role in setting the stage" for Pinochet's coup d'état. By 1973, the United States achieved the objective that Nixon's administration outlined in November 1970: to "destabilize Chile until the country was ungovernable."

By the narrowest definition of a “direct role,” the United States and CIA do not appear to have been involved in the violent actions of Pinochet’s coup d’état. In September 1974, Kissinger testified before the Senate Foreign Relations Committee, stating that “the intent of the United States was not to destabilize [Allende]” and the Nixon administration had “nothing to do” with the coup. However, historical records of the United States’ strategic covert interventions – including funding labor strikes, anti-Allende propaganda in newspapers, and issuing an economic blockade — prove otherwise. Following Nixon’s presidency, President Gerald Ford publicly defended U.S. intervention against Allende, asserting that the actions were “in the best interests of the people of Chile and certainly in [the United States’s] best interest.” Ultimately, Pinochet’s 1973 coup d’état in Chile was not only a tragic chapter marked by human rights abuses, but also a powerful example of how foreign interferences, driven by national self-interest, can undermine sovereign democracy.

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TO WHAT EXTENT DID THE VOTING RIGHTS ACT OF 1965 EFFECTIVELY ELIMINATE BARRIERS AND BOLSTER THE RIGHTS OF AFRICAN AMERICAN VOTERS?

Chingmo Zhou

Shanghai High School International Division '27

Introduction

The matter of race has been a persistent and complex issue interwoven throughout America's history. Despite the abolition of slavery in 1865 and their bestowment of rights, African Americans continued to suffer from immense marginalization, disenfranchisement, and discrimination. Near the wake of the twentieth century, institutionalized discriminatory and segregation practices against African Americans formed the Jim Crow Laws under the "separate but equal" doctrine. Again, these policies sparked public outrage and discord among the African American community, gaining immense momentum and influence through the Civil Rights Movement. Eventually, in 1960's, the US enacted new policies to undo the racially predisposed laws of the past, such as the Civil Rights Act of 1964, the 24th Amendment ratified in 1964, and importantly the Voting Rights Act of 1965. Aimed at bolstering voting rights of African Americans, the act effectively banned literacy tests, and most notably gave the government the jurisdiction to intervene in state voting policies. This paper explores the effectiveness of the 1965 Voting Rights Act in eliminating racial barriers in voting, delving into its significance in fostering racial equality as well as its influences on future legislation and public policy that continue to affect society today. Ultimately, although the Voting Rights Act did indeed represent an elimination of racial voting barriers and encouraged greater electoral participation in the short term, its impacts were greatly limited by evolving forms of voter suppression through counterproductive legislative acts on both the state and federal level that weakened the act's enforcement mechanisms.

Context

The Jim Crow era of modern America implemented a multitude of different measures to prohibit voting access for black individuals. Through methods such as poll taxes,

literacy tests, grandfather clauses, disenfranchisement clauses, and general intimidation ratified via the *Williams V. Mississippi* holding, the government attempted to retain white supremacy during electoral processes by exploiting loopholes in the 15th Amendment. However, as the Civil Rights Movement continued to gain momentum, these discriminatory policies came under immense public scrutiny, resulting in public policy changes that effectively overturned such biased laws. The 24th Amendment was passed initially in early 1964, putting a ban on poll taxes on a federal level. Subsequently, a year later, the Voting Rights Act was passed, further eliminating other discriminatory policies such as literacy tests and disenfranchisement clauses. Furthermore, clauses 4 and 5 of the act provided a clear formula and system of preclearance, which required all states to gain federal preapproval for any alterations in new voting practices or procedures, marking the most significant statutory change in the relationship between federal and state governments regarding voting processes since the Reconstruction era. In shorter words, the Voting Rights Act signified not only a significant moment in the advancement of the Civil Rights Movement, but also a monumental shift in the power dynamics between federal and state governments, an important change that set the stage for the future repercussions of the Voting Rights Act.

Positive Changes

The direct aftermath of the Voting Rights act proved to be beneficial in improving voter numbers and turnout among African American individuals. Electoral participation increased drastically, with a quarter million new black individuals registered, a third of which through federal examiners. Such changes were of a direct cause-and-effect relationship following the expansion of voting rights for black individuals that the Voting Rights Act granted, seeing that it opened up lanes for voter registration and eliminated other prohibiting barriers. In addition, given the socio-political circumstances at the time, voter turnout spiked after the act was initially passed, seeing that black individuals were eager to exercise these newly granted rights. These effects were especially prevalent in the South, where state-level voting restrictions were especially stringent on a large black population. As a result of the Voting Rights Act, state-wide electoral participation in all facets increased significantly, with black registration increasing in Mississippi from 28,000 in 1965 to 406,000 in 1984. This marked a general trend in stimulating civil rights activity in areas with high numbers of unregistered black voters, explaining the sudden surge in black voter registration. By the end of 1966, only four out of thirteen southern states had African American voter registration numbers less than 50%⁵³. Furthermore, the Voting Rights Act

also facilitated the increasing appointment of African American federal officials, especially in local, single-member district elections. States like Alabama saw a sharp increase in African American elected officials, with that number increasing from 72 to 1,469 in 1969. In addition, the Voting Rights Act also implicitly enabled local governments to intervene in state redistricting, reflecting the government's attempts to bolster African American federal representation, although this has left corridors for exploitation through racial gerrymandering. However, holistically speaking, both the direct surge in African American voter registration, voter turnout, and elected officials emphasize the direct effects of the Voting Rights Act in initially promoting electoral equality, proving that it was indeed effective in its goal of eliminating many previous barriers prohibiting equal voting; changes that still persist today.

Challenges and Negative Repercussions

Although the Voting Rights Act initially facilitated greater electoral representation and equality among African Americans, as time progressed it lost its effectiveness in enforcing racial electoral equality, prompting the development of alternative voter suppression mechanisms and increasing state-level retaliation. The most important clarification that must be made is that the Voting Rights Act, albeit promoting equality quantitatively, failed to resolve the deep racial tensions that continued, and will continue to exist. As such, as the act marinated, these tensions deepened and encouraged dissatisfied white voters to find other means of suppressing black individuals from voting and gaining influence. Interestingly, the Voting Rights Act led to increased political participation not only for African American individuals, but for the majority-white individuals too. This white voter activity was seen as a white counter-mobilization effort to offset the efficacy of new black voters, ultimately having long-lasting negative effects on white individuals' racial attitudes. Such activity suggests that the Voting Rights Act failed to tackle the root issue underlying electoral racial inequality, instead prompting counter-mobilization efforts to dilute the influence of black votes.

Another key method utilized to curb the effectiveness of the vast number of black voters now present was the use of racial gerrymandering during redistricting. The Voting Rights Act, in conjunction with the Equal Protection Clause of the 14th Amendment, implicitly allowed for the creation of majority-minority districts during a congressional redistricting to prevent minority vote dilution that was becoming increasingly present, as mentioned previously. In the 1986 Supreme Court ruling *Thornburg v. Gingles*, the government was able to prove voter dilution under the second clause of the Voting Rights

Act, ultimately setting the precedent for federal intervention of redistricting, given that the state could present “compelling state interest” to do so. However, some states were able to exploit this loophole stimulated by the Voting Rights Act to actively marginalize African American voters by drawing congressional districts to either separate them via hijacking, reducing their influence on district elections, or by congregating black voters together to minimize their sway over state elections through a process called racial gerrymandering. Conducting a brief case study on one of the first Supreme Court cases regarding racial gerrymandering in 1993, appellants in *Shaw v. Reno* that claimed that a majority black district in North Carolina, that awkwardly spanned 160 miles along the I-85 without being much wider than the I-85, was racially segregating black individuals via gerrymandering. Although the holding ruled the district unconstitutional and a breach of the 14th Amendment, it represents an instance that solidified racial barriers and diluted black votes, suggesting that the Voting Rights Act opened corridors that allowed for it to be exploited and backfire on its original intentions. In this sense, the Voting Rights Act was not entirely effective in eliminating racial barriers, as racial gerrymandering reinstates these barriers. Additionally, racial gerrymandering continues to be an issue today, as seen through the gerrymandering of Tarrant County in Texas, where newly drawn districts diluted the influence of the only black, democrat commissioner in the state. Therefore, although the Voting Rights Act may have been successful in its inception, the progression of time gave way for increased exploitation and misuse that have had serious repercussions.

Rising state-wide retaliation and challenges against the preclearance clause of the Voting Rights Act further diminished its power in enforcing equality and eliminating racial barriers. The most notable piece of legislation to directly respond to the Voting Rights Act, the landmark Supreme Court case *Shelby v. Holder*, effectively abolished the Voting Rights Act’s preclearance act, giving states jurisdiction and flexibility over electoral procedures without federal oversight. Sparked by the racially backed redistricting of Shelby County, Alabama that reduced minority representation by 40% and essentially removed Ernest Montgomery, the only black councilman in his city, the Supreme Court ruled that the preclearance clause was unconstitutional, holding that the federal government does not hold the right to interfere with state electoral processes. This has allowed predisposed racial tensions to reappear in state-wide voting, reverting the effectiveness of the Voting Rights Act greatly. States have also reimplemented stringent voting laws that negatively affect African American and minority voters, namely Texas which reinstated the country’s strictest voter ID law moments after the Shelby ruling, a policy that was previously denied due to its

failure to obtain preclearance. As such, the results of the *Shelby v. Holder* holding have had serious impacts on voter turnout rates among black individuals. Since 2008 to 2022, the white-black voter turnout gap has increased by 5 points, marking a significant increase in the disparity between black and white voters that was previously kept almost equal under the preclearance clause. This reflects the Voting Rights Act's importance in maintaining equality, suggesting that its preclearance clause was an integral element in maintaining voter equality, yet recent state level retaliation has struck down such protections, now rendering the Voting Rights Act as much weaker than it was before. Ultimately, despite its short-term benefits, the Voting Rights Act has weakened significantly, as in the long term it has struggled to effectively protect the rights of African American voters, allowing many racial barriers to be re-established.

Nuance

The Voting Rights Act of 1965 has had mixed effects: It saw immense success in solidifying the rights of African American voters, successfully eliminated stringent barriers such as literacy tests, and helped strengthen government control of state electoral policies; it also set the foundation for legal loopholes to be established that helped challenge the act and ultimately reverse its effects through the abolishment of the preclearance clause.

Compared to other notable Civil Rights legislation of the time, such as the Civil Rights Act and the Fair Housing Act, it had a very narrow focus and was effective in its purpose. Yet, its decline seemed sharper and more jarring than that of one like the Civil Rights Act. Although this might seem like the case, the underlying reason for its failure is not its effectiveness as a law, but the deeply ingrained racial tensions present in America. Like any of the laws of that time, they were all bound to be challenged because the deep divide between races in America could simply not be mended. Looking further, race-related socio-economic challenges, as well as general race-based biases were the key contributors to the Voting Rights Act's decline of effectiveness. Ultimately, these issues cannot and most likely will not be directly resolved, therefore rendering all Civil Rights legislation ineffective in the long run. However, it can be agreed upon that the Voting Rights Act and other legislation at the time were effective in solving the most foundational and most racially disenfranchising policies of the Jim Crow era, showing how its ineffectiveness in the modern era does not impair its efficacy as a whole in eliminating racial barriers and bolstering the most fundamental state of racial equality among voters.

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BLEEDING HEARTS AND BYLINES: HOW FEMALE WAR CORRESPONDENTS REDEFINED WAR, GENDER, AND JOURNALISM IN WORLD

Riley Qiu
Milton Academy '28

These women were feisty, whiskey-drinking, and brave.

As gunfire erupted across Europe in early September of 1939, World War II swiftly plunged the world into havoc. This severity heightened attention to war journalism as over 1,600 American correspondents swarmed to European and Pacific battlefronts to chronicle the war for millions of Americans at home. War correspondence was seen as an “unladylike” profession, however, excluding women as they were deemed unfit for undergoing the cruel reality of combat, destruction, and survival. Women in the field of war correspondence were given limited access to the front lines, having to fight hard to earn a place. Yet some women refused to give in to these constraints. Despite the systemic barriers imposed upon them, a select group of female war correspondents prevailed and transformed exclusion into opportunities. Through Martha Gellhorn, Lee Miller, and Sigrid Schultz—three pioneers in their fields—American female war correspondents during World War II navigated an exclusive profession by leveraging, rejecting, and redefining gender-based stereotypes. By focusing on the struggles of individuals in war, cultivating courage through war trauma and identity crises, and asserting authority in male-dominated spaces, these individuals transformed restrictive expectations placed on women into an overlooked form of feminine expression, thereby reshaping war journalism to foreground a more intimate and expansive narrative of World War II.

Gendered Constraints and the Emergence of Female Agency in War Correspondence

By the turn of the twentieth century, women were entering the field of journalism at increasing rates. As historians summarized based on the Census, the number of female reporters and editors increased by a striking 2,158 in the thirty years from 1870 to 1900. Still, this numerical growth did not translate to widespread acceptance of female journalists in professional and social contexts. More broadly, this marginalization extended be-

yond war correspondence: journalism and intellectual activities were already viewed as unsuitable for women, in contrast to their domestic roles. American housewives, for instance, were barred from scholarly pursuits as they were occupied with household labor. As Norma Yerger, a Utah housewife, reported amid World War II, after finishing all the chores up to expectation, she would always be “too weary to read any professional social work literature” while her husband retained the leisure to pursue intellectual activities. Even within the field of journalism, however, female reporters were nevertheless circumscribed. In the 1900s, female journalists were largely confined to reporting “soft news,” or news pertinent to fashion, society, and other traditionally feminine domains.

It was in the midst of such systematic constraints that some of the most ambitious and resilient women in the field of war correspondence rose to the occasion. Martha Gellhorn, a prominent American war correspondent, gained recognition for her frontline reporting on D-Day, persistently defying restrictions placed on women in the face of the brutality of war. Lee Miller, a model-turned-photojournalist, documented the cruel aftermath of war from evacuation hospitals to concentration camps, deploying a uniquely human and intimate lens that reshaped the narrative of war. Sigrid Schultz, the Berlin bureau chief of the Chicago Tribune, underwent continuous surveillance and threats from German officials, navigating both gender biases and identity crises while maintaining her authority. Through their work, these female correspondents not only secured a place in a profession that sought to exclude them but also did so by leveraging restrictive expectations, forging resilience in the face of trauma, and navigating authority in male-dominated spaces.

Leveraging Gender Constraints to Reframe War Narratives

When faced with stereotypes prohibiting them from entering particular fields regulated for male reporters, female war correspondents like Martha and Lee spent countless hours working in medical fields to focus on the perspective of war casualties, delineating a humanitarian perspective of war by leaning into such gender-biased constraints. Of the many accounts of major battles like D-Day, one conspicuous narration was that of Martha's. In the midst of Martha and her former husband Ernest Hemingway's scuffle, he had gotten a ticket on an assault craft to observe D-Day in person. Unwilling to miss the opportunity, Martha secured a berth on a Norwegian freighter carrying military equipment to Liverpool. Even so, she nearly missed the Allied invasion of Occupied France on July 6, 1944, when guards at the ship refused to grant her access due to her female identity. Martha then stepped onto a hospital ship, forged the excuse of an interview with the nurses onboard,

and stowed away in a bathroom stall for their journey across the English Channel. During the journey, as the ship became swamped by flocks of wounded soldiers, she posited: Piles of bloody clothing had been cut off and dumped out of the way in corners; coffee cups and cigarette stubs littered the decks; plasma bottles hung from cords, made shadows on the walls. There were wounded who groaned in their sleep or called out and there was the soft steady hum of conversation among the wounded who could not sleep.

In doing so, Martha had shrewdly transformed her gender identity from a barrier into a privilege; rather than reporting on the conventional grandiosity of the warfare, she shifted her reporting to a more individualized perspective. Not only did she note down the visual catastrophe of the environment in front of her, but she also observed that the wounded soldiers “talked among themselves[,] and as time went on[,] we got to know them, by their faces and their wounds, not their names.” Martha’s observations underscored that, in the face of war, individuality was too often lost—if not for her identity as a woman, the stories of the wounded might have been lost to sight over time.

Meanwhile, Hemingway’s account of D-Day, titled *Voyage to Victory*, focused heavily on his interactions with the American soldiers and coxswain, underscoring an apparent sense of pageantry as if the battlefield were a pomp of war. Concluding the article with “we had taken the beach,” Hemingway’s account of D-Day ultimately emphasized the triumph of the operation rather than the sufferings it entailed. In comparison, Martha portrayed, “Men smiled who were in such pain that all they can really have wanted to do was turn their faces away and cry, and men made jokes when they needed their strength just to survive.” In embracing the gender-based restrictions she faced at D-Day, Martha focused on the anonymous suffering of the individuals in war, rather than upholding a heroic victory, and reframed the narrative of war not as a stage for valor but as a cruel reality where human fragility was uncovered.

Similarly, Lee’s efforts at the 44th Evacuation Hospital also demonstrated the essence of the unseen suffering in World War II through her feminine journalistic expression. A month and a half after the D-Day landings in June 1944, Lee was assigned to interview and write a short photographic essay about the U.S. army nurses at the 44th Evacuation Hospital in Normandy, France. Rather than sticking to the assignment, however, Miller photographed sick patients, war casualties, skilled doctors, and nurses at the tents for five days, crafting an in-depth multipiece on the hospital. Case in point, Lee photographed Smoke or chat to see if he’s real, 44th Evacuation Hospital (see Figure 1). As captured, a patient at the hospital lies on his bed, his face revealing agony. Another soldier sits beside

him, looking at him with care and sympathy. Miller specifically titled this work “Smoke or chat to see if he’s real,” highlighting that, though the soldiers represented a larger nation at war, they were also humans with real losses and emotions. In capturing this true, vulnerable interaction between these two soldiers, Lee reframed them not as distant subjects of warfare but as emotionally complex individuals, often misrepresented in other accounts of war correspondence.

Moreover, Lee’s Bad burns case at 44th Evacuation Hospital (see Figure 2) further indicated her particular intent to signify the neglected sufferings of casualties in the war. As shown in the picture, a bad burns patient lies on a bed, looking at the camera. The bandages on his body are fully visible, showing the degree to which the war can impair an individual. Miller captioned, “A bad burn case asked me to take his picture, as he wanted to see how funny he looked. It was pretty grim, and I didn’t focus well.” As is evident in the photograph, the “grim” imagery of the patient’s extensive injuries and hollow eyes reflects the bleak reality and cruelty of war. Surprisingly, rather than being punished for her disobedience and straying off task, Miller’s work was so moving that it was published in full, with 14 accompanying pictures, under the title “Unarmed warriors.” Though it was reduced to four pages in American Vogue, it was still widely circulated, especially among people working in field hospitals, as their jobs often went overlooked. Ultimately, the work of female war correspondents like Martha and Lee at hospitals—focused not on the monumental moments of war but on the anonymous sacrifices and misery of wounded soldiers—tactfully leaned into the gender-based restrictions that barred them from the front lines to craft sympathetic pieces that represented the often-neglected facet of World War II.

Redefining Courage: Reshaping Trauma into Resilience

Beyond leveraging certain gender-based restrictions, female war correspondents like Lee and Sigrid also constantly confronted war trauma and identity crises to reject gender-biased stereotypes that suggested the violence of war was exclusively fit for masculinity, embodying the grace of courage in their pieces and work ethic. Sexually assaulted by a family friend at the age of seven and constantly taken nude pictures by her father, an amateur photographer, Lee developed a complex relationship with vulnerability and control that deeply informed her artistic lens. Consequently, rather than portraying the subjects of her photos as part of heroic imagery, Lee’s photographs often centered on moments of softness and intimacy, such as establishing a contrast between a child or a civilian and the brutal surroundings. As shown in her Young Girl in Hospital Bed (see Figure 3), taken

at the Vienna University Children's Hospital, a young girl lies confined with stark white railings, visually evoking both protection and entrapment. The photograph grows more disturbing upon noticing a ragged doll lying in the shadows to the left. The juxtaposition between a frayed doll and the vulnerable female subject who underwent the reality of fascism resembled Nazi Germany's brutal dehumanization. Through her deliberate focus on seemingly minor yet symbolic details, Lee challenges the conventions of photojournalism, compelling readers to confront the daunting costs of war. While the prevailing notion held that women lacked the fortitude to be war correspondents, Lee, by contrast, demonstrated that her sensitivity testified to her resilience and recovery from previous traumatic experiences, defying these stereotypes by practicing a deeper, more penetrating form of war journalism.

In the same vein, driven by her will to reveal the atrocities of concentration camps, Lee's reports on Dachau and Buchenwald established that resilience in war was not solely confined to physical combat but also defined by the willingness to witness and endure trauma. Days after U.S. troops liberated the Buchenwald concentration camp on April 11, 1945, Lee and Margaret Bourke-White arrived to document the aftermath of the camp. Upon entering, they found nearly 21,000 emaciated and near-death prisoners along with a block for medical experiments, a site for torture and execution, and a crematorium. Though the cleaning process had already begun and the initial shock of horror had largely subsided, Lee and Margaret still reported on the depravity they observed. In her *Freed Prisoners Scavenging the Rubbish Dump* (see Figure 4), the aftermath of liberation was stripped of any triumph in Lee's portrayal. In the photograph, prisoners wander drably in the rubbish dumps; their ghostly figures reveal how deeply dehumanization had permeated in Buchenwald, constituting the orthodox narrative of a triumphant liberation with a cruel reality documenting the lingering physical and psychological consequences of fascism. Furthermore, two weeks after her visit to Buchenwald, Lee arrived at the Dachau concentration camp with Dave Scherman promptly after its liberation. In comparison to Buchenwald's muted atrocities, Lee exclaimed, "Dachau had everything you'll ever hear or close your ears to." In the appalling remains of the concentration camp, Lee noted that she saw "the bestial death of the hundreds of starved and maimed men and women," demonstrating not only the horrid scale of suffering but also her refusal to step back from the cruel reality. Lee's unwavering endurance revealed that, rather than lacking the resolve to excel in their roles of war correspondents, women bore the willingness to confront, endure, and expose the war's harrowing realities. In doing so, she redefined the boundaries of courage in war

journalism, transforming the narrative of battlefield heroism to foreground the human cost of war.

On the other hand, operating with Nazi Germany, Sigrid confronted not only the inherent dangers of war correspondence but also a system of constant surveillance and targeted intimidation that threatened her identity as a Jewish woman. As the Nazi regime gradually consolidated power, Sigrid found herself constantly under latent scrutiny: her telephone calls were tapped, her mail was monitored, and even her household was under surveillance. These threats did not escalate until June 11, 1933, when Sigrid received her first summons to their headquarters from the Gestapo. Upon notice of her visit, the American embassy offered to accompany her, but Sigrid then responded in a letter that she “did not feel fidgety about anything” and was willing to “face the lions” alone. Sigrid remained resolute in the process, even if the officials made it clear that the truth was no armor against punishment. As Sigrid declared in the letter, “Some official thought a little summons to G.S.P. might prove intimidating, which was an extremely foolish thought. I have always made it a point to stick to facts as closely as humanly possible and I don’t see how anybody in his senses could object to factual reporting.” Her persistence under such conditions contradicted the notion that women lacked resilience to pursue war correspondence, demonstrating that courage was not limited to physical proximity to war but extended to the psychological endurance of political pressure.

Rather than backing down from the pressure in the ensuing years, Sigrid persevered with her exposé articles on the Nazi’s anti-Jewish legislation, political violence, and the erosion of civil liberties. In her 1938 article, *Hitler Seizes 20,000 Jews*, she underscored the “systematic destruction of Jewish property, looting, arson, and wholesale arrests of Jews without official charges,” while contrasting how the police “walked unconcernedly through the havoc-bent crowds as if everybody was out for an enjoyable afternoon stroll.” In documenting both the violence inflicted upon citizens and the state’s indifference, Sigrid exhibited her courage by not shying away from reporting brutal truths, knowing the risks of retaliation from authorities. Moreover, when Gestapo agents attempted to incriminate her by planting false evidence in her household, she directly opposed the Nazi military commander Hermann Göring, publicly accusing him of orchestrating the scheme. Rather than retreating from intimidation and surveillance from the Nazi authorities, Sigrid chose to define her courage through establishing her credibility as a fair and factual reporter, earning herself the name of “the dragon from Chicago” from Göring, one of the most powerful figures in Nazi Germany. As such, Lee and Sigrid’s work ethic ultimately reveals

that the courage required to be a female war correspondent was not solely defined by physical presence on the battlefield, but by the willingness to confront systems of power and reshape how truth could be documented.

Navigating Their Voices in Male-Dominated Spaces

Not only did they have to confront the inherent identity hardships, but the interactions between female war correspondents like Sigrid and Martha and male figures, both in professional and personal spaces, further revealed the constant need to navigate a path between cooperating with colleagues and confidants and rejecting relationships that caged them in traditional roles. As the Berlin office bureau chief of the Chicago Tribune, Sigrid operated within a male-dominated newsroom, often having to assert her professional credibility while resisting gender-biased notions that confined her to a more limited journalistic role. While most female journalists in the 1900s were expected to report “soft news,” many were dismissed as “sob sisters,” female journalists who were expected to report sentimental crimes. On the other hand, Sigrid deliberately rejected these stringent labels, namely the titles of “girl reporter” or even “newspaperwoman,” preferring to be called a “newspaperman.” Such a linguistic choice revealed not only Sigrid’s personal preference but also her acknowledgment of the gendered hierarchy associated with journalism, strategically aligning herself with male expectations to gain credibility.

In her workspace, Sigrid constantly confronted microaggressions due to her gender identity, so much so that she became accustomed to regarding them as humorous anecdotes. As one contemporary recalled, Sigrid remarked that she was often “the only woman correspondent . . . among all the big-shot males who looked upon [her] as a freak, if not a threat.” Under such conditions, Sigrid could not rely solely on her hopes and ambition to achieve her career goals but had to carefully calibrate her attitude without losing her sense of authority. In one instance, early in her tenure as bureau chief, Sigrid was denied entry to a banquet of economic leaders on the grounds that women were not allowed. Sigrid’s calculated wit became evident when, rather than bluntly confronting the situation, she decided to send in a note that read, “Are two hundred men scared of one woman?” Ultimately, the press leader stepped outside the room, laughing, and escorted Sigrid into the event. “One big boss after the other came over to interview the strange woman,” Sigrid reflected after the incident, “and from then on I never had any trouble seeing world leaders.” By astutely resolving the conflict with humor, Sigrid demonstrated that her success in a male-dominated space was not a simple task but was achieved through a careful strategy

that balanced respect for colleagues with a refusal to accept gender barriers.

Furthermore, while many women were expected to define themselves through relationships with men, Martha focused on establishing independence and prioritizing ambitions in her personal relationships, resisting roles that limited her career. In her letters, Martha unveiled her unwillingness to marry and share her daily life with a partner, considering marriage the “original anti-aphrodisiac.” This reluctance in a stable relationship was further demonstrated through the tensions in her relationship with Hemingway. In Hemingway’s play *The Fifth Column*, the character Dorothy Bridges, a blonde, American war correspondent, was modeled almost exactly after Martha. Consequently, Hemingway discovered an outlet for unleashing his discontent, outright describing Dorothy as a “bored Vassar bitch... [who] has had affairs, abortions, ambitions.” Indeed, Hemingway’s stark comments on her were somewhat true, for Martha’s affairs, abortions, and ambitions remained her top priorities as she slowly realized Hemingway’s expectations of dominance clashed sharply with her insistence on independence. Reflecting on his attitude towards her, Martha noted in her letters, “He was never kind to me... because I was the woman he wanted, which means the woman he intended absolutely to own, crush, eat alive.” In rejecting the emotional and social expectations placed upon her due to her gender identity, Martha’s relationship with men indicated that navigating a male-dominated world not only required professional resilience, but also the ability to resist personal relationships that imposed restrictive gender roles. Ultimately, through the experiences of Sigrid and Martha with male acquaintances, female war correspondents displayed that success in a male-dominated field required not only professional competence but also negotiation, resistance, and the redefinition of the orthodox expectations placed upon them.

Who Tells the War, Defines the War

In the course of World War II, female war correspondents were often pushed to the margins of gender-based exclusion. Women were denied access to a first-hand experience to witness gunfire, thought to lack the resilience to endure the hardship of war journalism, and were immured in traditional roles that sought to constrain their ambitions, as reflected in Hemingway’s remark to Martha, “Are you a war correspondent or wife in my bed?” These constraints, however, failed to limit the scope of their work. Instead, female correspondents harnessed the limitations in professional spaces and chronicled the sentimental suffering of war casualties. They rejected stereotypical notions and demonstrated their resilience through overcoming traumatic experiences targeting their identities. In

their interactions with men in their workspaces and personal lives, female correspondents navigated their surroundings by prioritizing their authority and ambitions, rejecting traditional roles that reinforced gender-based stereotypes and threatened their careers. Yet, their impact extends beyond the context of World War II. In foregrounding the struggles of individuality, these women laid the groundwork for modern-day journalism's emphasis on humanitarian focus and human-centered storytelling. Ultimately, these female war correspondents did not merely overcome exclusion but helped reshape the boundaries of journalism, transforming its usual narrative of a majestic triumph to the intimate realities of war sufferings and societal pressures. These women did not merely bear witness to the war; they redefined what it meant to witness it.

Appendix



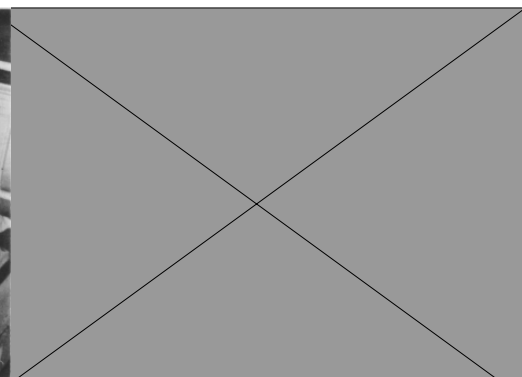
Lee Miller, Smoke or chat to see if he's real, 44th Evacuation Hospital, 1944, photograph, accessed April 1, 2026, https://images.leemiller.co.uk/media/_52s3RgyUy6xUVTW91P-coQ_a?ts=O_ij-45aKgvl0GefjyAYTKh-DQ7CtuWu2lw6hf-jo.a.



Lee Miller, Bad burns case at 44th Evacuation Hospital, 1944, photograph, accessed April 1, 2026, https://images.leemiller.co.uk/media/-A-bad-burns-case-asked-me-to-take-his-picture-as-he-wanted-to-see-how-funny-he-looked-It-was-pretty-grim-and-I-didn-t-1NKTEd_6Klg_P19RHCxXjw.a?ts=GgSMHmV7Jr9QGc8BFpHR8w.a.



Lee Miller, Young girl in hospital bed, 1945, photograph, https://images.leemiller.co.uk/media/yY8Zl2WYUsvasxeVSj6ZAg.a?ts=Hbr79uNm_PsHQWitujZlA..a.



Lee Miller, Freed prisoners scavenging in the rubbish dump, 1945, photograph, https://images.leemiller.co.uk/media/Lee-Miller-wrote-Prisoners-were-prowling-these-heaps-some-of-which-were-burning-in-the-hope-of-finding-something-more-ia1Ns6Alfdl92Qywoj1ryA.a?ts=Cq_T3Pnn1BW5tXw0Zl3xTkjiqCScfZf1-y91vl-Gitc.a.

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WORKERS OF THE WORLD, DIVIDE! THE COLLAPSE OF SOLIDARITY BE- TWEEN CHINA, THE SOVIET UNION, AND CUBA

Rhys Adams
Milton Academy '26

On the 1st of October, 1949, Chairman Mao Zedong proclaimed the existence of a very new state in a very old country. He announced the creation of the communist People's Republic of China (PRC) from the balcony of a palace where Ming and Qing dynasty emperors would customarily accept their "Mandate of Heaven" to rule the land of China.¹ This "Gate of the Heavenly Palace" (in Mandarin: Tiān'ānmén) would one day become synonymous with Chinese political repression, but in 1949, it served as Mao's stage to declare to the international community that a new dynasty had wrested control of the millennia-old Chinese state. In the traditional Chinese conception under the Ming and Qing, China was the undisputed center of global power, and all other kingdoms could engage with it only through a system of subservient tributary relations.² In 1949, though, China had been racked by nearly four decades of on-and-off civil conflict as well as the devastating Japanese campaigns of the Second World War; the People's Republic was overwhelmingly poor and scarcely recognized by foreign nations, but Mao and his allies were committed to restoring China to the very apex of world affairs. With the PRC preaching communism, the logical beginning for China's climb back to the top was seizing the reins of the global communist movement. For the next forty-two years, the duration of the Cold War, China's restorationist goals would grind against similar campaigns for international revolutionary leadership by the Union of Soviet Socialist Republics (USSR) and Cuba. The single-minded desire of the successions of self-styled "great men" leading all three countries, each promoting a slightly different communist philosophical ethic, would poison the potential for solidarity between the three and fracture 20th-century global communism irreparably. Cuban, Chinese, and Soviet plays at socialist primacy not only benefited the United States, theoretically communist internationalism's chief enemy, but also birthed a violent tripolar international order that smeared the final years of the Cold War with the blood of people

in the Global South who never signed up to be pawns in a great power competition. The ideologically intransigent diplomacy of Cuba, the PRC, and the USSR ultimately gave way to crude self-interest, coloring the history of Cold War communist international relations not as “the Moscow-Beijing entente” but rather as the infamous “Sino-Soviet Split.”

Sino-Soviet Relations Before the Split

In the earliest days of the PRC, officially declared in 1949 as Nationalist Kuomintang (KMT) forces fled to the island of Taiwan from the Chinese mainland via the ports of Xiamen and Shanghai, the attitude of Josef Stalin’s USSR towards Mao’s PRC was largely one of stern paternalism. Throughout the Chinese Civil War (1927-1949) and the Second Sino-Japanese War (1937-1945), during which the Communists conducted guerrilla campaigns against both the KMT and the Japanese Empire, CCP forces accepted some Soviet aid but kept the colossus of the North at arm’s length.³ In 1935, the Moscow-controlled Communist International, a union of global Marxist-Leninist parties meant to spread Soviet-style communism worldwide, had sent Otto Braun, a left-wing German military intelligence officer to South China, to assist the CCP in a civil war in which, at that point, they were losing badly.⁴ Braun took issue with Mao’s concept of “protracted people’s war,” a guerrilla strategy that relied on long-term informal support from peasants, pushing instead for more traditional combat tactics; Mao, however, was able to rally CCP officers against Braun as the KMT’s superior air force forced the Communists out of their enclave in Jiangxi province.⁵ After Braun’s dismissal, Mao led his troops on the rest of the famous 6,000-mile “Long March” with little to no Soviet support.⁷

Even after the Communists’ 1949 victory, Stalin was hesitant to acknowledge Beijing as an ally on equal footing with the USSR. The relationship between the two states was dogged by Soviet chauvinism, with Stalin’s cadre regarding the CCP as a pupil organization of the Communist Party of the Soviet Union (CPSU) and Stalinism as the only legitimate form of socialist political thought. When Mao visited Moscow for the first time in the winter of 1949-1950, Stalin—after nearly a month of negotiations—agreed to sign a new “Sino-Soviet Treaty of Friendship and Alliance” to rework the pact that the Soviet Union had previously made with the KMT in 1945. However, Stalin not only went seventeen days without meeting Mao, making the CCP chairman, per a telegram he sent that day, “so angry that [he] pounded the table,” but also left China deeply unsatisfied with the treaty provisions.⁸ In a January 1950 telegram to Liu Shaoqi, the CCP’s chief theoretician, Mao cabled from Russia that he and Stalin “mean[t] to put off the solution of the problem... until a few years later,” referring to the diverging interests of the USSR

and China pertaining to the United States.⁹ The USSR had fought alongside the US as an Allied power in World War II, receiving \$11.3 billion worth of weapons and strategically important goods from the US via the Roosevelt Administration's "Lend-Lease Program," and the terms of the Potsdam Declaration laid out an international order that featured a degree of US-USSR power sharing.¹⁰ Although Stalin told Mao outright that he viewed the US as unlikely to pursue aggressive military action against the Communist Bloc, the Soviet Union necessarily benefitted more in 1950 from stable, if pugnacious, East-West relations than China did. In 1949, Stalin had lifted the Soviet blockade of West Berlin, bringing to an end roughly a century of outright military confrontation between great powers in Western Europe.¹¹ Henceforth, the US and USSR tacitly agreed to do battle only on the territory of proxies along the imperial peripheries of both Washington and Moscow, which is to say, colonized and formerly-colonized countries. The key imperial players of the world wars were not to be subjected to such indignities. Mao viscerally feared that such grace did not extend to China. He left Moscow in February 1950 with a mutual-defense guarantee that only referred to Japan, \$60 million worth of credits per year until 1955, and an exchange of sovereignty where Beijing recognized Soviet-backed Mongolia and Moscow returned parts of Manchuria to Chinese control.¹² To many Chinese Communists, the Korean War confirmed their suspicions of Soviet negligence in the fight against Western imperialism. Chen Jian, a leading scholar of the Cold War in China, argues in a paper for the Cold War International History Project that Zhou Enlai was prepared to order Chinese troops into Korea without Soviet support and notes that Stalin cabled CCP leadership just seven days after China intervened in the war, asking them to "reconsider the decision."¹³ Although the Soviet Union did eventually lend air support to the cause of Kim Il-Sung's Democratic People's Republic of Korea (DPRK), China emphatically conveyed the message that it was neither a satellite of the Soviets nor a second-rate power.

When Stalin died in 1953, Sino-Soviet relations improved considerably. At his funeral, the three Soviet leaders who were grappling to take his place—Georgi Malenkov, Lavrentiy Beria, and Nikita Khrushchev—invited Zhou Enlai to stand at their side rather than sequestering him with the other ambassadors and foreign heads of state in attendance.¹⁴ When Khrushchev consolidated power, he dedicated enormous economic assistance to the CCP's "First Five-Year Plan," a nationwide development program modeled on the Soviet model of industrialization. Between 1954 and 1959, the total technical, personnel, and financial aid totaled 7% of the USSR's gross national income, making Khrushchev's contributions to 1950s China "the largest assistance program ever carried out from

one country to another.”¹⁵ At this point, both the Soviet Union and China turned their attention toward the Global South, with Khrushchev’s de-Stalinization extending to the reversal of the former dictator’s inward-facing philosophy and the CCP at last free to pursue peacetime diplomacy after decades at war. As such, the late 1950s saw an uptick in Sino-Soviet involvement in leftist political parties across Latin America, Africa, and Asia. As countries across those regions sought their independence, however, the more confrontational attitude with which their leaders faced the question of global imperialism put Khrushchev and his allies ill at ease. Most notably, Soviet leaders considered Fidel Castro’s 1959 Cuban Revolution “unorthodox” because the Moscow-approved Popular Socialist Party in Cuba had little to do with the initial rebellion that triggered Castro’s takedown of the once-US-backed Batista regime.¹⁶ Moscow soon reluctantly inaugurated an alliance with Havana. Not only did Castro’s victory spur the USSR to further engage with Latin American radicals in a bid to avert another unauthorized revolution from seizing control of a Latin nation, but it also cemented the perception that the CCP was more committed to global revolution than its Soviet counterpart, given the surge in agrarian-focused or even nominally “Maoist” movements in Central and South America since 1949. Soviet unease intensified in 1961 as US President John F. Kennedy undertook a US troop build-up in South Vietnam; Khrushchev refused to be drawn into a tit-for-tat escalation of the Vietnam War, which was indeed not yet considered a full-scale war on the US homefront, fueling the schism between the cautious Soviets and the sanguine Chinese.¹⁷

The Sino-Soviet Split

Amidst a succession of increasingly fervent domestic propaganda campaigns in China, the CCP elite turned on Khrushchev. In an attempt to shore up popular support in the face of the controversial agricultural policies that would grow into the disastrous “Great Leap Forward,” which eventually caused 10.3 million deaths due to famine, Mao began the “Anti-Rightist Campaign” in 1957, ostracizing and persecuting over 300,000 intellectuals by the end of the year.¹⁸ ¹⁹ This swing to the hard left did not spare the domestically liberalizing Khrushchev, who many Chinese Communists viewed as a traitor to the legacy of the more immoderate Stalin; Peng Zhen, Beijing’s lead CCP official, branded the General Secretary of the CPSU “patriarchal, arbitrary and tyrannical” in 1960.²⁰ Conversely, Khrushchev, put off by mass death under Mao and the insults of the CCP, canceled Soviet technological cooperation with China, pulling out funds and experts later that year.²¹ Furthermore, the CCP governor of Guangdong, China’s most populous province, held an event in February 1962 where he slammed Khrushchev as a false friend of the proletariat:

As far as I know his son-in-law often stays in the United States and keeps himself in frequent touch with U.S. high-ranking officials. What do they talk about? People scarcely know. As to Khrushchev's daily life, it is aristocratic. He has two private cars, a villa and two very fine television sets. Perhaps he wants to own everything in pairs and finds this convenient! But to us, the leaders, these are not necessities for the time being. If we need transport, we can board a plane, a train or a motor vehicle, none of which is privately owned; for recreation we can go to the clubs and the public stadium to enjoy ourselves; as to living quarters, we do not own houses, we rent them from the government. It may be that we don't want to live as Khrushchev does!²²

Months later, these tensions came to a head with the onset of the Cuban Missile Crisis, taking the Sino-Soviet Split from an ideological spat to a full-blown rupture of the international communist movement. After a thirteen-day confrontation over the stationing of Soviet medium-range nuclear missiles in Cuba, Khrushchev and Kennedy agreed to terms of mutual de-escalation, with the Soviet Union withdrawing its nuclear presence from Cuba in exchange for a US nuclear pullout from Italy and Turkey.²³ For the imperial cores of the two clashing blocs—the capitalist First World's core being NATO and the Soviet Communist Second World's core being Eastern Europe—this agreement represented an outstanding success, a step back from the brink of nuclear destruction. In Havana, however, the deal amounted to a surrender, a betrayal, and Castro did not want to leave his national defense in the hands of a Soviet government that appeared to be a “paper tiger,” as Kremlinologist William Garner described it in 1968.²⁴ The fundamental disconnect between the foreign policy interests of communists in Latin America and Eastern Europe rested in the fact that the US constituted an existential threat to the success of Latin American leftism while being a mere competitor to the USSR. While the risk of nuclear conflict loomed understandably large in both American and Soviet minds, the prospect of a ground war between the two great powers was highly unrealistic at the turn of the 1960s. Not much had fundamentally changed since 1949, when Mao wrote to Liu Shaoqi that “the [US] Americans ask other countries to fight the war [for them]”; if anything, Khrushchev's liberalization had made the US-USSR relationship even less likely to spiral into a clash of armies.²⁵ For Latin America, on the other hand, the clash of armies was a fait accompli: in 1954, the CIA had backed a coup against Guatemala's democratically-elected president Jacobo Árbenz to prevent his progressive program of land reform, and in 1961, Kennedy ordered an unsuccessful amphibious invasion of Cuba.²⁶ ²⁷ In the eyes of many Latin American communists, Khrushchev could visit the US—as he did in 1959, becoming the

first Soviet leader to officially travel to the West—to rub elbows with capitalist politicians and wax poetic about “peaceful coexistence” only because the bipolar US-USSR world order promised perks for its two poles that it would not afford to anyone else.²⁸ Just as the US had allowed Moscow to brutally crush democratic uprisings in Communist Hungary in 1956, the USSR extended the courtesy to Washington by not intervening on behalf of Guatemala in 1954 or Cuba in 1961 and standing up for Castro’s government for a measly thirteen days before recalling Soviet missiles from Cuba.²⁹ The message was clear: the great powers could exercise unilateral and aggressive military force unmolested in their geopolitical neighborhoods, and the Third World was a legitimate zone for more competitive shows of force. Mao, weighing his options and considering the chilly reception he initially received from the Soviet Union, chose to cast his lot with the Third World, becoming a founding member in the Cuban-led “Organization of Solidarity with the People of Asia, Africa and Latin America.” He bonded with Castro over Soviet fecklessness and their mutual desire to export revolutionary communism across Latin America.³⁰ This desire, though, was only really implemented in Peru, where the Sendero Luminoso guerrilla army declared a protracted people’s war against the military government in 1969.³¹

Indeed, two factors contributed to a resurgence of Soviet support in Latin America throughout the remainder of the 1960s: the ouster of Nikita Khrushchev in the USSR and the insanity of the Cultural Revolution in China. In 1964, Leonid Brezhnev and Alexei Kosygin collaborated to depose Khrushchev on grounds of incompetence, resulting from an accumulation of foreign policy failures epitomized by the worsening Sino-Soviet Split.³² From 1964 until 1980, the two men put the Kremlin through a drawn-out tug-of-war for control of the USSR, with Brezhnev gradually seizing the reins of state and boxing Kosygin out. Neither man being a foreign policy aficionado, the diplomatic posture of the Soviet Union became less dogmatic and more experimental in the aftermath of Khrushchev’s dismissal. In 1966, Kosygin agreed to mediate talks between India and Pakistan in a bid to secure a lasting ceasefire in the Kashmir Dispute, resulting in the “Tashkent Declaration,” which prevented a broader international escalation of the conflict and ensured the long-term non-alignment of India.³³ A Soviet diplomat present at the three-nation conference remarked that:

Events in India have the attention of the entire world. This vast country of 500,000,000 people is determining, not only the destiny of India itself, but important questions of the future of Asia. India has for years been an influence in the balance of progressive and reactionary forces in the international arena.³⁴

Such a reframing in CPSU circles of non-alignment as a noble stance against Western imperialism rather than the moderate form of it demonstrates that the Soviet Union faced pressures to grow less ideologically discerning in its choice of international partners. Just seven years after icing out Castro for forming a heterodox communist party, the USSR's embrace of decidedly non-Communist India confirmed the ardor with which Moscow was courting the "People of Asia, Africa and Latin America" for whom China purported to speak. As the USSR turned away from pure ideology, China turned firmly toward it. At the inaugural meeting of the Cuban Third World solidarity organization in 1966, hardline Chinese diplomats alienated African and Latin American delegates with their vituperation of the doctrine of "peaceful coexistence" with the West.³⁵ According to the January-February 1966 edition of the pan-Communist magazine *Communist Affairs*, China's diplomatic overtures at the conference failed miserably:

In November [1965] a group of Chinese "tourists" had paid an 18-day visit to Cuba. The group's leader was Lá Hsi-san, a member of the CPC international liaison department, which works to extend contacts with foreign Communists. The first delegate to arrive in Havana was a member of the Peking delegation. He arrived Dec. 14 and was joined almost at once by other early arrivals from China, who apparently were ensuring themselves ample time for pre-conference lobbying and discussions. Nevertheless, Chinese pre-conference moves were on the whole not very effective. They were unsuccessful in opposing the inclusion in the Conference of reference to peaceful coexistence, nuclear tests or disarmament; not a single country supported them. They protested against the proposed attendance of pro-Soviet groups from countries which also had pro-China factions and were supported by the Vietnamese, but the general opinion went against them. The exclusion of the Yugoslavs was a minor triumph for the Chinese, but it was their only one at the preliminary meetings.³⁶

This uncompromising CCP attitude towards other states occurred in the context of one of the largest campaigns of political repression in human history: the Great Proletarian Cultural Revolution. The "Cultural Revolution," as it has since been less propagandistically rebranded by Mao's more moderate successors, contained two phases of era-defining mass violence by Chinese against Chinese.³⁷ Although the Cultural Revolution's decentralized manifestations make parsing the blurred lines between its sub-epochs a difficult proposition, broadly speaking, the first phase—a true "revolution" in that it subverted the existing structures of power—lasted from 1966 to 1968, and the second phase—a reactionary counterpurge by the military establishment against its enemies—lasted from 1968 until

1976, when the whole affair descended into internecine factional conflict in Beijing.³⁸ All in all, during the decade between 1966 and 1976, the Cultural Revolution “caused 1.1 to 1.6 million deaths and subjected 22 to 30 million [people] to some form of political persecution,” according to the political scientist Wang Yuhua, with most of the violent deaths in question coming during the reactionary period of state repression.³⁹ Amidst this repression, through which the Chinese People’s Liberation Army (PLA) managed to usurp control of China’s domestic and particularly foreign policy, the unceremonious end of the US war in Vietnam and Mao’s increasing fear of the Soviets pushed the US and China to pursue a rapprochement process beginning in 1972 and concluding after Mao’s death in 1976. This normalization process would go on to permanently cleave China away from the USSR and make way for the tripolar power model that would frame international relations until the end of the Cold War. In the following years, Deng Xiaoping, after securing his spot as the CCP’s strongest post-Mao figure, effectively Sovietized much of the Chinese economy, largely disintegrating the notional conflict between the USSR and China as a rift between agrarian and industrial socialism. Thereafter, realpolitik accrued influence in the foreign policy apparatuses of all three great Cold War powers, and ideology took a back seat. However, the forces driving the initial estrangement between Moscow and Beijing relied fundamentally on the parallel developments of Maoism and the Soviet-style command economy, both doctrines whose parameters were tested in the political crucible of 20th-century Latin America.

Marxist Ideological Competition in Latin America

The first flush of nominally “Communist” parties in Latin America modeled on the CPSU and its early Bolshevik leaders depended on Vladimir Lenin and Leon Trotsky’s wishful prediction that the fall of Tsarist Russia, the perennial arsenal and creditor of right-wing European movements, would inexorably topple Europe’s fragile capitalist hegemony, beheading the global imperial system of exploitation and swiftly giving way to worldwide revolution.⁴⁰ Unfortunately for the Communists, however, the successful defense of Warsaw in the 1918-1921 Polish-Soviet War impeded the westward march of the Bolshevik Red Army, preventing the confederation of “Soviet republics” that would soon become the USSR from spreading communism to Germany, the most industrialized country in mainland Europe at the time.⁴¹ Lenin and his comrades, swamped by a lengthy civil war raging in Russia, left their Central and South American imitators to fend for themselves in the 1920s. Marxism-Leninism, the Soviet brand of Marxism that entailed hierarchical, authoritarian one-party rule, did not mesh well with the on-the-ground conditions of most Latin

American countries for two reasons. First, except in Mexico, where the incumbent Partido Revolucionario Institucional outlawed the Catholic Church during the 1926-1929 Cristero War, Catholicism held spiritual if not outright political influence across the political spectrum in Central and South America, clashing with the harshly-enforced state atheism demanded by Marxist-Leninists.⁴² Second, the decentralized Spanish-American model of caudillismo, in which charismatic leaders (caudillos) build localized agrarian power bases and command loyal private armies, stood opposed to Lenin's call to assemble an intellectual vanguard to harness the revolutionary energy of urban wage laborers.⁴³ Thus, in the absence of material support or strategic guidance from Moscow, the original party-line Marxist-Leninists of the Americas achieved next to nothing in the 1920s and 1930s, staging only one revolt, the failed 1927 Coluna Prestes in Brazil, and winning no elections.⁴⁴ Incipient Maoism enjoyed a more obvious appeal. At least in theory, protracted people's wars appeared more realistic across the Americas, where the historic foundations of insurgent power aligned with China's. Although the percentage of Latin Americans living in municipalities with more than 20,000 residents sat at 25% in 1950, between China's 10% and the USSR's 32%, the legacy of the Spanish-American states' independence processes endowed them with a propensity for rural-reliant guerilla warfare.⁴⁵ Despite a slew of rapid secessionist conflicts during and after the successful revolutionary wars of Spain's mainland American colonies from 1808 to 1821 fragmenting the four American viceroyalties of the Spanish Empire—New Spain, New Granada, Perú, and Río de la Plata—into nine constitutional republics, Latin America began to buck the global trend of internal conflict as they aged. By the early 20th century, Latin America's civil wars were exclusively non-secessionist: they advocated revolutionary regime change.⁴⁶ Andreas Wimmer, a sociologist of civil conflict, notes:

In general, Latin America's civil wars are not well described by our model. Despite high degrees of ethnic exclusion in many countries (of the Amerindian population in Peru, Bolivia, Ecuador, Guatemala, and Mexico, or of the black populations in many former plantation societies), none of the civil wars have been fought along these lines. The pathways leading to revolutionary civil wars not covered by our model seem to be traveled with considerably higher frequency in Latin America than elsewhere.⁴⁷

While secessionist or nationalist internal conflicts depend on cosmopolitan, urban centers' insurrectionary energy to disseminate national literature, unite the national intelligentsia, and serve as a capital-in-waiting, diverse anti-government coalitions not rooted in any particular region or culture, like those typical of Latin America after indepen-

dence, rely less on the urban middle class and can build valuable support networks among the peasantry. China, having more peasants by percentage than all of the mainland Latin American countries, unsurprisingly demonstrated more rural political consciousness than the USSR. On the decentralization axis, Maoism also won out: although Mao would turn vehemently against Confucius later in life, for the first decade of the PRC, he maintained the time-honored Confucian principle of devolving nationwide control to provincial governors, allowing for local autonomy and significant self-determination for minority nationalities.⁴⁸ Latin American communists rallied around Mao; the PRC hosted left-wing activists from Cuba, Brazil, Colombia, Honduras, Chile, and Guatemala within three years of its existence.⁴⁹ Even the official, Soviet-line “Communist” parties understood the benefits of Mao’s decentralized, agrarian politics: in 1953, the Bolivian Communist Party’s José interrupted a meeting of Bolivia’s largest trade union congress to demand that a proposed land reform bill be replaced with a new proposal, a nearly word-for-word Spanish translation of China’s 1950 Land Reform Law.⁵⁰ The CCP formalized its outreach to Latin America in 1956, when the “Chinese People’s Association for Cultural Relations with Foreign Countries” sent a cultural delegation to Argentina, Uruguay, Chile, and Brazil; in 1958, the preeminent Chinese state-owned radio station doubled its Spanish broadcast time, which reached 21 hours per week by the end of the decade.⁵¹ The somewhat cordial Sino-Soviet relationship at this moment even convinced Khrushchev to place the Brazilian Communist Party under the express tutelage of Beijing.⁵² One Latin American state—Cuba—would pioneer a new socialist political platform while tightening its ties with China; the CCP, though, would eventually discard Cuba as insufficiently radical.

Fidelismo

Mao’s early focus on land reform left the CCP top brass somewhat disconnected from the urban proletariat. Indeed, Mao classified the peasantry as a revolutionary class, a break with Marxist orthodoxy that removed the urban wage worker from its philosophically privileged position. This decentering of urban organized labor left unions in major cities dissatisfied with CCP leadership; between 1952 and 1957, five labor demonstrations against bureaucratic or autocratic management took place in Shanghai and Taiyuan, with dozens more protesting more concrete indignities like politically-motivated pay docks.⁵³ Although Chinese urban diets substantially increased in nutrient richness from 1953 to 1957, the rapid industrialization of the First Five-Year Plan did not contribute to the increased political influence of urban labor leaders or CCP officials.⁵⁴ Moreover, the CCP’s morality laws were far more permissive toward the cultural quirks of rural provinces

and minority regions than the cosmopolitan youthquake taking place in China's largest cities, especially given the KMT's long period of pro-Western social policy in the cities they controlled, which included most of the former Western treaty ports, coastal cities where imperial powers like Britain and France could sell manufactured goods, on China's eastern seaboard.^{56 57} The CCP, despite its history with the New Culture Movement, cracked down early on such displays of "bourgeois reactionary thoughts" as drug use and vagrancy.⁵⁸ Thus, the potential issue for Mao, Zhou, and Liu rested not in the abject material conditions of urban laborers driving them into revolt—although these days would come—but rather the stunted political ambitions of urban Communists and social liberals occasioning an interregional power struggle, the last thing China needed in the 1950s. Simultaneously, the man Mao would eventually brand as "the little Khrushchev of the Caribbean" had developed a program of urban-rural synthesis that Mao would manipulate abroad to score points against the USSR in the Global South but fail to model domestically, to the ultimate detriment of China.⁵⁹

In part due to the far more widely-documented and notorious labor crackdowns of the USSR, union leaders and trade congresses in the Western Hemisphere somewhat soured on the role the Soviet state played in international socialism.⁶⁰ The PRC's disdain for peaceful coexistence with the US and its more full-throated support for Fidel Castro's revolutionary government in Cuba earned it curious support from Latin American organized labor. In his 1961 survey of Sino-Latin relations, Daniel Tretiak explains the moment that made this hidden group of supporters clear to the CCP:

...[T]he Chinese apparently found some Latin American union leadership highly interested in the hard-line of the [PRC] when some of that leadership attended the World Federation of meeting in Peking in June 1960. Comments from Brazilian, Chilean, Venezuelan, Mexican, and some Central American pro-Communist labour unionists were extremely favourable to development in China, omitted praise for Soviet leadership, and expressed interest in the use of armed struggle against pro-American governments in Latin America.⁶¹

Castro's early synthesis of the interests of trade unions and poor farmworkers fueled his success in toppling Batista.⁶² Although Soviet-backed organized labor, namely the Confederation of Cuban Workers (CTC), stood against Castro's "July 26th Movement" until the eve of its victory, Castro deployed targeted political maneuvers over the course of his rise to power that lessened the diverging interests of the peasantry and proletariat, winning their support as individual citizens rather than as members of a work team or com-

mune.⁶³ This approach distinguished Castro from the Eusebio Mujal of the CTC, who not only was a notoriously corrupt man with a \$280,000 salary in an impoverished country, but also benefited from the perks of capitalism under Batista.⁶⁴ Historian of revolutions Steve Cushion summarizes these perks in his book on the Cuban revolution:

Trade unions, as their name implies, are organised around sectional divisions that reflect the economic structure of capitalism, which in turn institutionalises the divisions between different groups of workers...As long as the role of a union is seen as defending workers' interests within the capitalist mode of production, with its differential wage structure, these divisions will remain...The trade union...has developed interests of [its] own, different from the mass of workers they represent, which depend on their ability to mediate between capital and labour. This leads to a more conservative social view, even amongst those who started their trade union career as class conscious militants, with a resulting propensity to vacillate.⁶⁵

Thus, when the July 26th Movement formed a strike committee in Guantánamo in August of 1957 to spread anti-regime protests in the wake of the brutal police killing of one of Castro's guerillas, they shut down the city within a day by coordinating guerilla actions with the growing general strike.⁶⁶ The strategy to which Octavio Louit, the leader of the July 26th Movement's Sección Obrera (labor wing) credited this victory subverted the typical union structure. Louit boasted of *núcleos obreros combativos* (combative workers' cells) that brought together small numbers of urban workers, sometimes across professions, to synchronize the actions of the resistance in the countryside and in the cities.⁶⁷ After forcing Batista out of the country permanently and assuming the Cuban prime ministership in February 1959, Castro moved quickly to bolster urban-rural solidarity. He pushed through the Rent Reduction Act, which redistributed roughly 15% of Cuba's total wealth from landowners and industrialists directly to laborers and peasants.⁶⁸ On a political level, programs like Cuba's rural literacy campaign enlisted young revolutionaries in the cities to volunteer in the countryside, reducing interregional animus while also boosting Cuba's outcomes in education, healthcare, and infrastructure.⁶⁹

Mao praised Castro because the CCP chairman saw Cuba as a launchpad for China's aspirations to Third World leadership. In the early 1960s, this Chinese offensive gained little traction outside of Cuba, with Beijing-funded socialist coups failing in Mexico, Venezuela, and Brazil between 1961 and 1964.⁷⁰ Still Castro collaborated closely with Mao, buttressing the latter's attempt to co-opt global revolution. Even before the Cuban Missile Crisis, the two nations signed a five-year trade agreement that allotted \$60 million of agri-

cultural development aid to Cuba and Chinese assistance in planning the Cuban sugar industry.⁷¹ After the Cuban Missile Crisis stunted Soviet-Cuban relations, Castro followed Mao's lead in doing away with the influence of the Soviet-style education system in Cuba, which both men saw as overly intellectual, in favor of broader vocational programs.⁷² Kossygin fought hard to win back the support of Cuba from the Chinese Communists, and the Soviet aid drive he directed benefitted the Cuban sugar industry with far more success than the Chinese aid package.⁷³ ⁷⁴ In January 1966, Cuba terminated its Chinese rice import quota, bringing an end to Sino-Cuban agricultural cooperation and infuriating Mao.⁷⁵ As the CCP's radical wing continued to ascend in power, however, the calls for isolation and dogmatism inside China grew louder. On May 16th, 1966, Mao's declaration of subversive elements within the CCP was published nationwide, marking the beginning of the Cultural Revolution and severing any immediate chances of reconciliation with Cuba.⁷⁶ The most important factor in the undoing of Fidelismo's potential sway over global politics came as a result of its failure to capture any Latin American governments but Cuba's. When the Castro domino effect did not materialize, the caudillo of Havana lost his shot at leading the Latin American struggle against the US.

In 1966, Fidel Castro proclaimed Cuba's most notoriously communistic policy: level income.⁷⁷ Essentially, Castro resolved Cuba's ideological "great debate" over central economic planning by opting against the Khrushchevist model of government bonuses to highly productive workers.⁷⁸ Jettisoning the individual focus he had favored early on, Castro leaned heavily into a collectivization regime that combined the USSR's strict party control with China's commune-style economy. In the spring of 1968, Castro rolled out his most authoritarian plan yet: the "Revolutionary Offensive" essentially conscripted all available Cubans into military-style work brigades that were forced to contribute to the 1970 sugar harvest.⁷⁹ Quickly, Cuba became the country with the highest percentage of nationalized firms on any continent; Castro also came out firmly in favor of the Soviet invasion of Czechoslovakia, indicating a degree of solidarity with crackdowns against more populist socialism.⁸⁰ Amidst this jarring pivot, Castro also tried to position Cuba as the principal state in a new Latin American political order. Around 1966, Castro dispatched his revolutionary comrade Che Guevara to South America, assigning him to put together fidelista guerilla cells in Bolivia, Argentina, and Peru; although these uprisings gained some ground with some in the ranks of the dissatisfied rural poor, Argentina's military intelligence was too robust, and Guevara had no political strategy for courting indigenous people in Bolivia or Peru.⁸¹ In 1967, Bolivian forces executed Guevara. On the diplomatic front, Cuba was

not much more successful. Soviet-backed communist parties held back from fully lending their support to the spread of Fidelismo, even when Moscow purported to work with Castro, whose radical bent turned off even sympathetic nearby states like Mexico, which was the only member of the Organization of American States to maintain diplomatic ties to Cuba after the Cuban Missile Crisis.⁸² Cuba's repeated encouragement of radical leftism in Mexico frustrated Mexican President Gustavo Díaz Ordaz, who began pushing the US line in his talks with Cuba.⁸⁴ Castro's catastrophic policy pivot was a bid to maintain power against liberals in his coalition who wanted normalization with the US and demanded "Fidelismo without Fidel."⁸⁵ For the remainder of the decade, Castro vigorously centralized Communist power in Cuba, hoping to homogenize the once diverse segments of the July 26th Movement with his nationalization campaigns. He succeeded in uniting Cuban leftists but squandered Cuba's political capital with leftists abroad. The failure of the much-awaited labor-intensive 1970 sugar harvest ended Cuba's idealistic visions of global revolution and Cuban leadership of the Latin American cause, and the pragmatism Castro was forced to adopt was reflected in the status of the Sino-Soviet Split in the late 1960s. Castro had tried, as part of his push for Cuban primacy, unsuccessfully to distinguish his foreign policy from that of the USSR. He bucked Brezhnev at the UN by voting against the Treaty on the Non-Proliferation of Nuclear Weapons in 1968, considering it a play at the dreaded doctrine of peaceful coexistence with the US.⁸⁶ Additionally, many of the insurgent groups he supported in Latin America were enemies of the CPSU-approved parties in their respective countries. Soviet leaders found this insubordination to be of such concern that they allegedly deputized Aníbal Escalante, a former Cuban revolutionary demoted by Castro, to oust Castro in favor of more CPSU-friendly Cuban Communists.⁸⁷ Escalante was caught and imprisoned as a part of Castro's largest purge in 1968, but Cuba could not resist the influence of the USSR forever. From 1969 to 1970, during the bungled Revolutionary Offensive, Soviet sugar subsidies to Cuba increased 99.2%, and in 1972, Castro agreed to adopt a Soviet economic planning stratagem and fall under the USSR's auspices in the Moscow-led Council for Mutual Economic Assistance.⁸⁸ The ideological selectivity of the 1950s no longer seemed feasible to Third World communist parties as the violence of the Cold War intensified. Latin Americanist William Garner wrote in 1968 that "the Chinese have allowed many Marxist-Leninists to cloak their growing impatience with the rate of change [coming from the USSR] in the façade of the Maoist position," yielding a number of "Maoist" parties in the Global South that neither practiced nor even understood Maoism.⁸⁹ Conversely, many parties long estranged from the USSR, including the

Communist leaders of Romania and Yugoslavia, softened their stances towards Moscow to distance themselves from the excesses of the Cultural Revolution.⁹⁰ As socialists the world over retreated from ideological rigidity to more shrewdly position themselves in the geopolitical arena, the beginnings of a similar process were forming in hardline China.

China's Turn to Realism

During the reactionary latter half of the Cultural Revolution and into the beginning of the Dengist reform era, the PLA accumulated pivotal political power in China where it had previously been outflanked by civilian CCP apparatchiks. During China's First Five-Year Plan and Mao's escalating leftist campaigns, Beijing was serious about restraining the power of the military. After the Korean War ended in 1953, Mao ordered a demobilization plan that would see China's military spending fall from 42.5% of overall budget expenditure in late 1951 to a mere 8.3% in 1960.⁹¹ The first of the radical purges, the Sufan Movement and the Anti-Rightist Campaign, relied not on the PLA to enforce terror but instead on community actions mere steps away from protracted people's wars. In fact, the first of many high-level Communist leaders to fall victim to a Maoist purge was army marshal Peng Dehuai, the inaugural target of the 1959 "Anti-Right Deviation Struggle."⁹² The political winds changed direction for the PLA, however, when in July 1968, the CCP Central Committee called in the armed forces to quash the student uprisings and workers communes that had sprung up during the insurgent phase of the Cultural Revolution. One of the student radicals suppressed at this point, Ding Xueliang, describes his sudden reversal of fortunes:

A few people called the "dictatorship team" came in. The person who was declared a criminal was dragged out of his seat. Then, two from the dictatorship team would hit the person's legs with their rods so that he kneeled. Then they'd handcuff you and announce your crimes. They shoved your head down. The rest of the audience would shout slogans, and you were dragged away. It was scary; you never knew who'd be next.⁹³

The PLA held tightly onto their newfound political capital even as the cultural counterrevolution died down. The USSR's aggressive subjugation of Czechoslovakia's 1968 Prague Spring demonstrations and the 1969 border clashes between Soviet and Chinese troops along the Amur and Ussuri Rivers in Manchuria left Mao terrified of an impending Soviet invasion.⁹⁴ Thanks to this panic, the PLA was able to step further into the topline fray of the CCP. Chen Jian and Cold War international relations historian Odd Arne Westad explain the personal maneuvers of this period:

As the country suffered, political infighting at the top intensified. The main trend in 1970–

1971 was still the increased role of the army, with Lin Biao as its leader. Many of the new provincial [CCP] secretaries were army people, as were many of those who staffed the central [CCP] institutions that were slowly reemerging after the chaos of the late 1960s. Though some leading officers were skeptical of Lin's leadership skills, or fell afoul of his inconsistencies, the overall feeling among the generals was that Lin Biao was a better alternative than the Cultural Revolution leadership, which most of them despised intensely.⁹⁵

The increased control of the PLA drove China into a repressive, conservative period. To quiet the voices of students, the PLA closed most of the universities and high schools not already ruined by interfactional combat; of course, this move also quieted the already hushed voices of educators and academics.⁹⁶ The military also turned its back on the PRC's record of relative respect for minority nationalities, singling out Tibetans, Uyghurs, and Mongols for repression. In the Inner Mongolia Autonomous Region, the PLA framed the ethnically Mongol former CCP Vice-Premier Ulanhu for organizing a fictitious Soviet-backed separatist plot.⁹⁷ In the purges that followed Ulanhu's removal, the army arrested around 800,000 Mongols—over 30% of Inner Mongolia's total population in 1970—and killed around 100,000.⁹⁸ The PLA's crackdown from 1968 to 1976 pulverized the few remaining progressive aspects of Mao's PRC: advances in the rate of education, rights for women and minorities, and expanded local autonomy dissipated whilst the army sternly disciplined the rowdy Red Guards.

Against the backdrop of this political whiplash, Lin Biao's corps made good on their promise to court the US. Although members of the CCP hard left like Mao's wife Jiang Qing opposed any collaboration with the American government, which they viewed as irrevocably imperialist, the moderates were able to secure Zhou Enlai as an emissary to secretly meet with US President Richard Nixon's national security adviser Henry Kissinger in 1971.⁹⁹ Reprising the power-sharing playbook behind the Khrushchev-era thaw in US-USSR relations, Kissinger offered a gradual pullback of US assets from China's regional sphere of influence. Once an end to the Vietnam War was brokered, he assured Zhou, the US would "permit the political solution of South Vietnam to evolve and to leave it to the Vietnamese alone," in addition to suggesting a full US military withdrawal from Southeast Asia and Taiwan.¹⁰⁰ The next year, Richard Nixon became the first US president to visit China, signing the "Shanghai Communiqué," which publicly pronounced the consensus Zhou and Kissinger had achieved. The only red line the two countries drew was in Korea: otherwise, the US seemed to be done with its forward presence in the Asia-Pacific region.¹⁰¹

US authorization of effective Chinese regional hegemony both validated the PLA's sway over China's foreign policy and neutered China's aspirations of sponsoring global leftism. In 1974, Mao and Zhou, by then both already weathered by age, set their diplomatic sights on ties with capitalist West Germany.¹⁰² They understood US-aligned Western European countries, most of which were NATO members, as a trap in which to entangle the Soviet bloc. Mao saw the USSR as fundamentally expansionist and "social imperialist," so he resolved to induce the Soviets to pursue expansion or, at least, low-level conflict on their western front in Central Europe rather than their southern front: Mongolia and China.¹⁰³ The Shanghai Communiqué only accelerated the path of Beijing's realist, non-ideological diplomatic posture, and the batch of soft-right CCP leaders set to succeed Mao concurred with this orientation. In 1974, as the reformer Deng Xiaoping built back his power after his 1968-1971 internal exile, he called on the influential army to form a base of support.¹⁰⁴

In 1976, Zhou and Mao both died of old age. In the time between Zhou's passing in January and Mao's passing in September, the CCP hard left responded to the refusal to disperse of a Beijing crowd of Zhou's mourners by ordering the massacre of the demonstrators and manipulating the crisis to demote Deng and pull the increasingly senile Mao back to his radical roots.¹⁰⁵ Once Mao died, however, he was no longer able to insulate the leftist "Gang of Four," consisting of Jiang Qing and three other Cultural Revolution hardliners, from the profound unpopularity of their policies. Twenty-seven days after the chairman breathed his last, his presumptive successor Hua Guofeng collaborated with Deng's inner circle to arrest the Gang of Four and consolidate power around the broad, moderate coalition that has governed China since.¹⁰⁶ Most Chinese supported or accepted the autocoup, but the hard left Shanghai Revolutionary Committee organized protest marches with a prescient slogan: "Never allow the experience of the Soviet Union to be repeated in China."¹⁰⁷ The Revolutionary Committee and their ilk were by then already bound for the ash heap of history, but their warning proved somewhat accurate: as paramount leaders of China, Hua and eventually Deng would rerun much of the domestic and foreign policy of the Khrushchev thaw, just on a different Communist polity. Once Deng boxed out Hua in 1978, he turned to an economic policy not unlike Khrushchev's centrally-planned experimental market strategy of *sovnarkhozy*, promoting modest autonomy for provincial governments to facilitate centrally-assessed competition between them.¹⁰⁸ Deng also ordered the testing of different policies in different regions, like those that occurred under *sovnarkhozy*, with Sichuan and Guangdong pioneering, respectively, the rural and urban economic systems he would go on to expand nationwide.¹⁰⁹

Deng repeatedly criticized the legacy of Khrushchev to domestic and international observers, but the details of these statements suggest that Deng's ire focused more on Khrushchev's personal style than his political or economic program. In 1974, Deng had argued that "making a clear break with Khrushchev's line was impossible" for Brezhnev and Kosygin, who continued many of their predecessor's policies while easing Khrushchev's assault on intraparty democracy, an ironic analysis given Deng's employment under Mao at the time.¹¹⁰ Still, when members of Deng's government lobbied him to advance a normalization process with the USSR, he refused outright.¹¹¹ In his view, an imperialist power that shared a strategic area of interest with China could never be China's friend.¹¹² Thus, counterintuitively, the tradeoff for China's softening and, to a certain degree, Sovietization of their economy was a sustained aggressive posture towards the USSR itself. In fact, Deng gave an interview to an Italian journalist in August of 1980 where he predicted an impending Third World War:

The [World] war is inevitable because the superpowers exist and because their imperialism exists. And the inevitability of war isn't just a view of the Chinese: many people in the world are convinced that the war will break out in the '80s. The next 10 years are very, very dangerous. They are frightful... It is since the end of the Second World War that the people in the West keep talking about peace and detente, and so does the Soviet Union. But where is the peace, where is the detente? Year by year, if not day by day, the hot spots increase, the factors which will drive to the third world war, and those people go on chatting about peace and detente.¹¹³

Despite this bluster, however, the only war the Chinese under Deng fought against a Soviet-aligned military was the 1979 Sino-Vietnamese War, in which the China invaded the Socialist Republic of Vietnam to stop their southern neighbor from ousting Pol Pot's Khmer Rouge regime in Cambodia, one of China's few remaining incumbent proxies after the diplomatic calamities of the Cultural Revolution period.¹¹⁴ Vietnam, to Deng's surprise, repelled the PLA and successfully installed a Hanoi-backed government in Cambodia, but the war's outcome revealed less about the final chapter of Cold War politics than did its belligerents: unlike the Vietnam War that had ended roughly a decade earlier—where, per 1967 CIA estimates, the USSR sent North Vietnam 45,000 tons of aid each month and provided 50% of North Vietnam's yearly overseas imports—Brezhnev's refused to directly deploy Soviet force against China, instead simply continuing the logistical assistance to Hanoi that the KGB had been supplying throughout the Vietnamese campaign in Cambodia.¹¹⁵ ¹¹⁶ As the dust settled following China's shocking defeat,

their new US partners coaxed them into accepting a model whereby all three great powers could expand without stepping on each other's toes. This system of three poles—Beijing, Moscow, Washington—would redefine Cold War competition in the 1980s.

Tripolarity and its Consequences

The tripolar dynamic between China, the US, and the USSR during the 1980s was an extension of the *détente* between Washington and Moscow following the 1972 Strategic Arms Limitation Talks Agreement.¹¹⁷ Following this preliminary collaboration between Brezhnev and Nixon on stepping back from the nuclear brink, US defense spending declined sharply.¹¹⁸ Even so, Cold War conflicts in the Third World persisted, with conflict escalating the most in Africa and the Middle East, far from either the Soviet or American immediate sphere of influence. The superpowers still reaped their own benefits from their more direct bilateral de-escalation, with trade between the US and USSR increasing throughout the 1970s and peaking in 1979 at 1% of the US's total trade volume.¹¹⁹ Soviet militarism, however, did not fall off as a consequence of *détente* like Nixon's diplomatic team had expected; the USSR's defense spending increased as a percentage of its total gross national income from 1970 to 1975 and again from 1975 to 1980.¹²⁰ Then, on December 27th, 1979, the USSR deployed troops into its proxy the Democratic Republic of Afghanistan to suppress the anticommunist rebels of the Islamist mujahideen, seizing the reins of Afghanistan's already mostly subservient government in the process.¹²¹ To US President Jimmy Carter, this invasion, similar in strategic value—though starkly different in opponent—to the Soviet invasions of Hungary in 1956 and Czechoslovakia in 1968, marked the failure, and therefore the end, of *détente*. Moscow's apparent head start on militarization gravely threatened US interests. In 1979, the US accounted for 56.2% of NATO's total defense spending, and in a bipolar system, the imbalance of brute force between the two great powers suggests an impending war.¹²² Carter and his National Security Advisor Zbigniew Brzezinski did not view the world at the turn of the 1980s as essentially bipolar: they saw China as a great power, and they needed to make sure that Deng felt the same way. US thinkers preferred tripolarity to bipolarity at this point because it seemingly promised a lower risk of any power's elimination. Dylan Motin outlines this line of thinking as such: Assume that A, B and C have more or less equal resources. If A seizes B's resources, C would have no means to compensate for the resulting imbalance of power. Consequently, C has to assist B to prevent A's victory. In such a configuration, no great power would ever be eliminated. A great power under attack will always receive the unconditional assistance of the neutral third. Since coalitions against the aggressor emerge automatically and quick-

ly, a pole has little incentive to attack another and should be content to keep the status quo... In a bipolar system, a weakening pole is unlikely to survive for long since any power imbalance is impossible to correct.¹²³

With the benefit of historical hindsight, many present-day political scientists argue that the USSR was, in fact, economically spiraling in the 1970s and 1980s, that Carter and Brzezinski had little to worry about, but the Soviet-Afghan War demonstrated Brezhnev's confidence, and the US saw itself falling militarily behind its sworn enemy. To remedy this divide, Brzezinski presented Deng with the opportunity to create a united front against the USSR. The two men subsequently reached an agreement on Taiwan, where the US theoretically accepted the principle that Taiwan was a continued belligerent in the Chinese Civil War rather than a republic independent of China, and Deng propositioned Brzezinski for advanced US technology that China could use to outgun the Soviets.¹²⁴ Although Brzezinski could not fully oblige, given US export restrictions pertaining to Marxist-Leninist states, Israel began supplying the PRC with "missiles, avionics, tanks, and more" at the beginning of the 1980s.¹²⁵ ¹²⁶ Although the US gradually lowered weapons export barriers for China until 1989, the Israeli defense industry had served as a middleman for US military aid to regimes that the White House did not wish to publicly support since at least 1977, so Israeli support to the PRC also fell in line with US interests.¹²⁷ ¹²⁸ The Soviet-Afghan War exemplifies the success of the US's handing off to China the responsibility for fighting the USSR on its borders. China's Xinjiang Autonomous Region became one of two major staging grounds—along with northern Pakistan—for the incorporation of foreign aid, external training, and technical assistance to the mujahideen, with the PLA assisting in instructing its fighters, many of whom were Sunni Muslim volunteers from beyond Afghanistan.¹²⁹ The PRC also delivered up to \$400 million worth of artillery to the mujahideen in the 1980s, more than double the CIA's estimate for the total PLA budget in 1979.¹³⁰ ¹³¹ Deng continued to support the anti-Soviet effort over the course of the decade, committing combat aid to fight the USSR's proxies in Sri Lanka and Ethiopia, although in 1982 he declared the "independence and self-sufficiency" of China's global stance, trumpeting to the world that China was not a US-aligned power but a neutral pole choosing to collaborate against the concerning power of the Soviet Union.¹³² Tripolarity did not immediately give way to peace, though: both the frequency and the deadliness of armed conflicts crescendoed in the 1980s, with the starkest increases by both metrics coming from the Middle East, followed by Sub-Saharan Africa.¹³³ ¹³⁴ Because neither of those regions were in the explicit neighborhood of any of the three great powers, the trip-

olar system unsurprisingly made them more violent, because it combined an increase in military capabilities with a disincentive for the US, China, or the USSR to fight each other directly, as they did in Korea and Vietnam.

Conclusion

Cuba, at this point a satellite of the USSR with hardly a foreign policy program to speak of, could not continue its resistance to the US in Latin America. The US ramped up its anticommunist violence in the region in 1975, when Henry Kissinger and the CIA financed the creation of Operation Condor, the first explicitly militaristic pact between the US and multiple Latin American countries.¹³⁵ Operation Condor brought together right-wing military dictators in Argentina, Bolivia, Chile, Paraguay, Uruguay, and, eventually, Ecuador, Brazil, and Peru; throughout the campaign, the armed forces of each of these countries kidnapped, tortured, and killed tens of thousands of suspected leftists, marking a graphic escalation in the lengths to which the US was willing to go to assert dominance over its sphere of influence in the Western Hemisphere.¹³⁶ In 1980, the situation escalated again with the election of Ronald Reagan, whose political program sought the downfall of global socialism in every regard, and during his term, US involvement in El Salvador, Guatemala, and Nicaragua drove all three countries' civil wars into their deadliest years.¹³⁷ In the period from 1975 to 1991, however, Cuba only dedicated its own troops, at the behest of the USSR, to conflicts in Africa and the Middle East, where the great powers were jockeying for control.¹³⁸ The Cuban dream of a Latin American uprising against the US fizzled out.

For a brief moment in 1958 and 1959, as the Cuban Revolution claimed its victory, Mao, Khrushchev, and Castro were nominally united. After the fallings-out to come, the three countries those men represented would never again be aligned all at once; the Soviet Union collapsed in 1991 with the Sino-Soviet Split still potent across the continents. Were the raw, realist geopolitical interests of the three countries simply so divergent that a dispute was inevitable? That explanation seems unlikely, given Kosygin and Zhou's mutual hopes of diplomatic rapprochement in the mid-1960s, the initial benefits of Sino-Soviet involvement in Cuba, and the fact that Soviet and Chinese economic development came into full swing only once each power implemented an economic program it had once belittled in the other. The most potent impediments to cooperation between China, the USSR, and Cuba were the egoistical projects of their leaders: Mao's obsession with purifying the revolution; Castro's self-appointed stint as representative plenipotentiary for the Black, Brown, and Asian people of the world; and finally, Brezhnev's expansionist military buildup, the

economic stroke of foolishness that cost Russia its colonial empire after two-and-a-half centuries of dominance in Eurasia. The structure of Marxist-Leninist ruling parties claims to eliminate factionalism, but it only serves to displace factionalism to one level below the very top, creating sycophantic competition for the approval of the paramount leader. Few achieved the insanities of Mao and Stalin's reigns, but one-party rule in any context lends itself to cults of personality nonetheless. These cults had leaders from China, Cuba, and the USSR confusing themselves for their countries and failing to imagine a world beyond their term. As such, most of them felt the need to drastically reshape the world order within their own lifetime and, of course, on their own terms. The extent to which "great men" shape history remains a subject of debate, but the hazard of seeing "great men" in one's own time shines through clearly in the Sino-Soviet-Cuban fiasco of the 20th century.

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